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Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34977706.

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Mature

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Princess, Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - Stripper/Exotic Dancer, Weddings, Gyms, Fake/Pretend Relationship, Mutual Pining, Horse Nerd Adora, Mullet Catra, Non-Binary Adora, Masc4Masc

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Hot Mess

by lologoblens, RaptorRed

Summary

Catra doesnt want much;steady work, the health and happiness of her friends, and, you know, for her unbearably hot workout buddy to wake up one day and fulfil all of her tawdry locker room fantasies. Apparently that's too much to ask for, so instead she gets this;Adora of fering to *pretend* to be her partner for the duration of a long weekend. And why? So Catra doesnt have to go stag to her ex's wedding. h which she is a bridesmaid. Naturally. t' s a terrible idea really, but how could she say no to an offer like that?
f only she knew how much more complicated things were going to get the night of the bachelorette party after the entertainment for the night walks in the door;A stripper scheduled by the groom who goes by the name *Princess*.

Notes

A heads up before we begin;this fic is currently rated M, but there is some potential for a bump up to E as we go on!W ell give y'all a heads up once that's decided if it does happen!

See the end of the work for more notes

A Dumbbell to the Heart

Catra stretches and runs a hand through the damp ends of her freshly cropped mullet. She slams the door of her gym locker shut and glances back toward the showers, huffing when there's still no sign of her workout buddy. Knowing they're gonna be thorough as ever, she falls onto the closest bench and scrolls through her phone for a bit. Mermista's bridal party group chat is going off again, this time debating which bars to hit at the bachelorette party next week.

It's gonna be a fucking train wreck but, hopefully, the fun kind. As long as it's better than Perfuma and Scorpia's combined bachelorette spa weekend, that was...memorable, to say the least. Getting baked out of her gourd and getting massages sounded like a good idea until she became hyper aware of her skin, and the most ready snack were the cucumbers over her eyes, and everyone else's. If she never saw a cucumber again, it would be too soon. She's just shooting off a text with her own suggestions, and playfully bashing all of Lonnie's and Netossa's, when a sprinkle of water drips onto her screen.

"Watch it, asshole." Catra growls, not bothering to look up as she finishes her message.

Unbothered, Adora ignores the dig and asks, "*Oh*, who ya texting, Cat?"

"None of your business."

"That means it's a girl, huh?"

Catra rolls her eyes and looks up. She shouldn't have; Adora's still wrapped in a towel that is *a* too small, their long hair in disarray from being shaken out. They're practically begging to be the star of Catra's latest locker room fantasy. The most recent one is still haunting her; Catra is changing, and turns to find Adora coming in

after a few extra reps. They look at her with a hunger that can't be satisfied by the smoothie shack. Next thing she knows Catra is pressed against the locker. Tongue, teeth, and screaming orgasms follow. Anyway, it's nothing new at least, so Catra shakes it off and manages to reply with some level of composure.

"Multiple actually . I have a whole harem going if you'd like to join. Though I should warn you, we're very selective."

Adora huffs playfully and turns away to open their own locker and dig out street clothes. "What? You're saying I'm not your type?"

A gorgeous, sweet and charming thembo that makes her heart flip flop with every smile? Yeah, that's been Catra's only type since she met this dork. Figuring it unwise to explain to them just exactly how completely and utterly *wrong* their assessment is, Catra leaves it at, "Just not sure you could keep up, Sparky ."She glances up from her phone to wink at them, regretting it instantly while also reveling in the sight of Adora in only a tank top and boxers. "I'm fucking insatiable."

Adora turns red at this but laughs. "I'm sure you are."They pull on their cargo shorts- looking far better than they have any right too, then their shoes. Grabbing their bag and slamming the door shut, they say, "Alright, I'm ready for a fresh Starla Original, you all set?"

Sta . Also known as the fucking bane of Catra's entire existence. It' s not fair, not really. In fact, they used to be sort of friends. Friendly acquaintances more than anything, but still. And by all appearances they still *are* , but, well, then Adora joined the gym. Just like that, Starla went from being the harmless cutie working the juice bar to Catra's crush's crush. Thus earning her Catra' s unrelenting, undue resentment.

"Yup, just remember;you're buying."

"No way!"Adora argues as they exit the locker room. "Y ou cheated, it doesn't count if you cheat."

“A deal’ s a deal, Adora. You didn’t say *for* three.”

They laugh, “I did so! And even if I hadn’t, you started running on two!”

“Hm, not how I remember it.”

“Rock, paper , scissors.” they suggest.

“A w, Adora,” Catra begins to tease, pulling open the door to the juice bar and holding it, “if you wanna scissor me, you can just say so.”

They turn red, naturally , and breeze past her . “Please, if I were propositioning you, you’d know .”

Catra’s mood instantly sours cause, yeah, she does know what Adora looks like when they’re making a move. She just wishes she knew what it was like to be on the receiving end of that attention. “Just for that, I’m getting a large.”

“Great, more for me when you can’t finish it.”

“Hm, well enjoy my back wash.”

“Gross!” Adora reaches over , giving Catra a playful shove. She goes to push back but they’ve reached the counter and Starla is ready and waiting for them, so she just crosses her arms instead.

“Morning, y’all!”

“Hey Starla.” Adora drawls, the register of their voice dropping in a way that would make Catra shiver if it wasn’t for some other girl. “I missed you yesterday.”

She giggles and her cheeks turn pink. Catra hates her. “W ell, I gotta take a day off sometime, you know.”

They lean on the counter , propping their head up on their hand. “And where’s a pretty thing like you go when you’re not here?”

Starla slaps their shoulder lightly, still giggling like a vapid school girl. Catra will chide herself for her unkind thoughts later, she's too busy being bitter at the moment. "You're shameless, you know that?"

"Oh," Adora waggles their brows, "I know it."

Starla shakes her head, curly hair bouncing in it's ponytail. "Am I making you your usual?"

Adora stands, taking the cue to scale back the flirting. "Please, and if you don't mind, add the mango again?"

"Liked that, did you?"

"You know I like *everything* you do, Starla."

She rolls her eyes, her smile making it clear the gesture is all for show. "Alright, a number four , add mango. Anything else today?"

"Yeah, I'd love the power greens salad, and whatever this one is getting." *Tone , barely* .

"Catra, usual for you as well?" Starla asks, her tone all business. Well, still friendly, but the difference is clear.

"Please, but I'm gonna go large today . And an egg sammie too."

"You got it! Cash or card?" Adora hands over a card and Starla rings them out quickly .

While she gets their order ready, Catra and Adora grab napkins and their respective condiments and cutlery. They head outside to claim their usual table, and Adora pops back in to grab their order. Catra waits outside, happy to miss any additional flirting that might be going on at the counter inside.

Adora emerges, a total vision; and not just because they're coming out bearing food. It's quiet at the table at first, both of them stuffing their faces, hungry from a long workout. Once their food is all but

gone and they're each sipping at their smoothies, they settle in to chat for real. Or at least they're going to, but Catra's phone interrupts.

"You're really blowing up today."Adora comments, eyebrows raised.

Catra rolls her eyes, briefly checking the preview on her lock screen. Unsurprisingly it's just further bar debate. "Yeah, you remember that wedding I told you about? My friend Mermista?"

"Mermista."Adora's brow furrows. "I think I remember this but I feel like I know that name from somewhere else too."

"My ex?"Catra prompts.

"*Oh*"Their expression clears and they grab their smoothie off the table for another long pull.

"The bachelorette party is next Saturday so the group chat's going off."

Brow furrowed again, they ask, "You're going to your ex's bachelorette party?"

"I mean, I'm a bridesmaid, so yeah. It's kinda part of the deal."

Adora snorts. "You're standing up for your ex at her wedding? Could you be more of a lesbian cliche right now?"

Catra laughs and punches their arm. "Shut up! It was like, a few months freshman year of college. We were terrors."

"Yeah, I can see that."

"Fuck off."she says with a snort. "We're just too similar for dating to have ever been a good idea, but Merms is chill."She winks and adds, "Hot too."

Adora rolls her eyes. "I'm sure."

Catra's phone goes off a few more times and she glances at it, rolling her eyes at the continued debate. Looking up at Adora again she sighs and says, "Initially , she asked me to be the photographer. That was a hell no from me. She can terrorize someone else. I do kinda wish I'd been able to find a plus one before RSVPs were due though."

"You're not bringing anyone?"

Catra shrugs and shakes her head. "Plus ones are for partners only . A way to curb expenses at least a little. Wouldn't be so bad if I weren't, not only the ex, but also the only single member of the wedding party."

Adora winces and sucks their teeth. "Ooh, yeah, that' s rough."

"Tell me about it."Catra says dryly , tossing her phone face down at the table.

There' s a beat of silence where Adora sits, staring at Catra's phone. Then, out of fucking nowhere, they of fer, "I could go with you."

Catra's heart stops. "Excuse me?"

Adora sits up a little more in their chair and reinforces the suggestion with, "Totally! I'll be your plus one. I love weddings."

"I first of all, who *does* weddings? And you did hear the part about plus ones being for partners only, yeah?"

"First, weddings are dope, fuck of f. Second, I mean, we can pretend for one night, right? No biggie."

Catra shakes her head. "It' s a destination wedding, we'll be in Sealineas for like, four days."

"Oh."Adora frowns. "W ell, I mean, if it'd help you out I can miss a couple days of class. When's the wedding?"

Catra swallows thickly, her heart beating way too slow to be functioning properly. In fact, she's fairly certain there's nowhere near enough oxygen going to her brain right now. "Three weeks from Saturday."

"Okay, yeah! That gives me plenty of time to check in with my professors. Do anything in advance I need to."

"Aren't-Aren't your horse courses like, really intense?"

"It's equestrian studies, Cat, and I mean, it's grad school, so yeah. Not like I can't take a couple days off here and there though, and if it's over a weekend." They trail off, shrugging nonchalantly like they're not rocking Catra's world right now.

"Can you even act? I mean, you don't know most of my friends, but Scorp is the best man. She knows you well enough to know if you're bullshitting."

Adora smirks, like there's some secret Catra's not in on. She's probably just reading into it though, her senses on high alert. "Oh, I can act. Pretended to be both straight and cis for like, seventeen plus years, didn't I?"

"Fair point, but still...you're gonna have to act like-like-"

"Like I like you?" They ask, smirk growing. "I mean, sounds rough, but I think I'll manage."

"Gee, thanks."

"I'm kidding!" they say with a laugh. "Seriously, it's not like your friends are gonna be expecting us to have our tongues down one another's throats or anything. And I'm happy to do my own thing while you're off doing...I don't know, bridesmaid shit. If you're uncomfortable with it, I-"

I'm not uncomfortable!" Catra defends, her voice bordering on shrill. She clears her throat and continues, "I'm not, I just. I don't want to, like, put you out."

Adora gives her a cheeky grin. "Well I don't know about *putting you*, but" Catra's face is heating rapidly, and she's pretty sure she choked on her tongue but then the dreamy smile fades. "I'm the one who offered, Cat." they say, their voice softening with understanding. And then they take her hand from where it rests on the table to hold it in their own. Suddenly Catra wonders if it wouldn't be so bad to have Adora pretending to be into her for a long weekend. It'll probably hurt later, but she can get over it. Live with the memories to comfort her.

"Okay"…

"Yeah?" They verify, perking up.

"If you want to, I guess it *would* be nice to have a buddy."

Adora makes a weird face but it's gone in a flash. "Totally!"

"And I'll pay for your flight and stuff."

"Catra, no, you don't have to do that."

She shakes her head firmly. "No way, Adora. You're doing me a favor, and I *know* how broke you are paying for classes and all your horse shit."

"Okay, well it's not *shit*." Catra gives them a look and they clear their throat. "Not the point. What I *mean* to say, is if you're sure then yeah, I'd appreciate it but it's not necessary. I'm happy to help, no incentive required."

"I'm paying." Catra says with a note of finality. She doesn't realize until it's out of her mouth that she's essentially agreeing to this ridiculous scheme.

"Cool. Holy damn, okay . Uh, I guess should we sort out our story? Oh! What's the dress code for the wedding? My graduation suit should still fit, but if that's too formal"…

"Yeah, no, I'm sure your suit is fine. They're not getting married like, on the actual beach."

"You know what the venue is?"

Catra rolls her eyes, smiling despite herself. "Merms parents are loaded so they rented out the entire fucking Sealineas Aquarium."

"That's so fucking rad."

"I guess, I know Mermista is excited, she's about as into fish and shit as you are horses."

"The ocean is freaky . Did you know like, eighty percent of it is still unexplored?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "I dated a marine biology major and then she stuck around for another five years or so; yes, I'm aware."

"So weird."

"You realize you're getting way off track here, don't you?"

"Right! Sorry , so, story."

"Yeah...I mean, I guess we should just stick to some version of the truth? Especially since Scorpia knows you. We met at the gym, hit it off." Catra hasn't imagined telling this story to any friends, no not at all. Even in her daydreams she leaves out the part where she dropped a dumbbell on her foot the first time Adora caught her staring. It was the whole reason they first talked, Adora rushing over to make sure she was okay, but it could be something much more slick in this telling.

"You lusted over my impressive bench weight." Adora says as they lean back in their seat, flexing like an ass. Too close to the truth for Catra's liking.

"Please, relatively speaking, I have you beat."

"Maybe, but I can still press more than your body weight." Catra wills away her blush at the reminder; she is in fact, well aware. "So, we met at the gym." Adora continues.

"Uh, yeah, and I guess...now we're"… *Don't be a fool, don't be single!* "dating."

"Who asked out who?"

"Uhh"…

Adora smirks. "Let's say I asked you."

"Whatever ."

"How long?"

"Maybe a few weeks now? Still new , so it makes sense I'm only just telling them."

"Cool, we could even say we put a label on it today , since that's kinda true."

"Okay , yeah." Catra clears her throat and feels her face heat. "Are you, uhm, okay with sharing a room?"

Adora nods, a little more serious. Not much, but still, a little. "Yeah, that's fine." Catra loves the enthusiasm.

"Cool, um, I'll book your flight when I get home today and send you the details? I think we should still be able to fly together , and I could always change my ticket."

Adora shakes their head. "No, you should go with your friends, you're in the wedding party after all. If I need to lag behind, that's fine."

"Okay." Catra bites her lip, her stomach spins nervously. "Adora, are you *sure* you want to do this? The whole charade?"

"For sure!"

"Okay ...well, uh, if you want to come to the bachelorette party next week, partners are invited. Might be good to meet everyone once beforehand?"

Adora frowns but nods, leaving Catra confused until they say, "You said it's next Saturday." Catra nods. "I have a study group that evening but I could come after if that's cool. How late do you think you guys will go?"

"Knowing that group? They'll be kicking us out of the bars."

Adora laughs. "Okay, cool. I'm not sure what time I'll- well finish up, can I just text you to find out where you're at?"

"Works for me."

"Great!"

"Yeah." Catra agrees, not sure if she *actually* agrees or not. "I guess I'll send the RSVP tonight. I guess the only question left is; Chicken, steak, fish, or veggie?"

Dancing B nies

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"I still can't believe Seahawk got you a stripper ."Catra mutters to the already halfway to smashed bride to be. "If this is how the night is gonna go, Catra's glad she refused the loudly proclaimed "Shots!" upon her arrival at Mermista's bachelorette party. "If they both get too wasted, a fight's probably gonna break out at one of the bars later. Not between them of course, but them against any poor schmuck that might throw an errant eye their way. "It was one of their favorite pastimes when they dated. Two drunk freshmen taking on whatever asshole frat boy decided to call out "Give us a show babes." They were birds of a feather in that way , and in others, which is why they're both hovering at the entrance of Perfuma' s living room, trying to get a peak at the entertainment before the show officially begins.

"He' s just that kind of guy , he won't go to a strip club with me, but he'll give me cash and a kiss on the cheek before I go." Mermista brags, swirling her glass and shoving off of the wall. Still not fully able to support herself, she falls straight into Catra, leaning on her shoulder instead. "But you'll still go with me right? As long as that mystery date of yours doesn't mind?" She scof fs and adds, "Y ou know, I can't believe you found a date at the eleventh fucking hour . I was *so* looking forward to watching you try and hook up with one of the bridesmaids. Really lean into the cliche."

Catra scoffs right back. "And who exactly would I be trying it with? Perfuma? Cause I think Scorp would have something to say about that. And not like Net's an option either. Spinny would skin me alive."

"Y our point?" Mermista whispers in her ear , leering playfully.

Catra just rolls her eyes. "My point is that was never gonna happen, date or no date."

"Aw, what's the matter? Not game for a threesome?" She winks and says, "You've gotten so tame since college."

"Oh please, you were even less down for that shit than I was."

"Hm, well maybe you've gotten boring, but I'm ready to expand my horizons. Last night of freedom and all. What's say you, me, and the-" Catra cuts her off with a groan. "What? Anything's game when I'm on the table."

"A stripper Merms? She' s working, not trying to get laid. I cant believe you, that so-"

"Oh my stars Catra, I'm trying to get a rise out of you, and look at that;it' s working. You need to get on my level, it's not as fun if you're being all sober and serious."

"I'll be plenty buzzed, but I'm not letting *you* get in a brawl tonight. Your wedding is right around the corner. I'm not gonna retake photos for you if you get a black eye."

"Just a little more before the show starts. Come on, before Perfuma shoos us away again."

"*Fine*." Catra concedes, shoving Mermista off of her. "I'm pouring though."

"No fun." she complains, following Catra to the kitchen anyhow.

Catra just snorts at the assessment. "Yeah, well neither is blacking out from your heavy handed pours."

"I'm not that bad."

"Uh huh, tell that to the Catra from that party Sophomore year. She might believe you, I on the other hand, am not buying what you're selling. So. Vodka, tequila, or whiskey?"

Mermista gives her a look and says, "I'm of fended you even have to ask."

"T equila it is!" She goes extra light on Mermista's pour, taking advantage of Lonnie coming in to gush about her own excitement for the upcoming show and making Merm's drink while she's distracted.

"What about you, Cat?" Lonnie asks once she's made her own drink and turns around, leaning against the kitchen counter to take a sip. "Y ou've gotten laid the least recently of anyone, how's it feel knowing you're finally gonna see a real life ass in a matter of minutes."

"Shove it, Lonnie." Catra grumbles into her drink.

"Hey!" Mermista says, far too loud and *far* too close to Catra's ear. "Y ou dont know that. Our girl here finally managed to find a plus one."

Lonnie's brows raise and she crosses her arms. "That so?"

Mermista, apparently on Catra's defense now, steps in to answer for her. "Sounds like a real hottie with a body too. Y ou remember Stable dick?"

"No shit?" Lonnie asks, looking a little impressed. Catra would be smug about it if not for the fact Adora's only coming out of some combination of pity and being a good *host*. "From the way Scorpia was talking, I never thought you'd get it up to make a move."

"Y eah, well," Catra starts, pausing to drain the rest of her drink and grimacing at the burn, "I did."

"So, you *have* seen a girl's ass live and in person recently."

"What is your obsession with whether or not I'm getting laid all the sudden?"

"I'll take that as a no." Lonnie laughs at her . It makes Catra's blood boil- even if she is right.

"We're taking it slow, asshole! Adora's...classy." Lonnie gives her a look. "Shut up!"

The weak defense just makes both her friends laugh at her expense. Lonnie claps her on the back, hard enough she's glad her glass is empty lest she spill all over Perfuma's precious hardwood, and she advises, "Well, you might wanna speed things up before the wedding. Unless you *want* your first time with the enbabe of your dreams to be in a shitty hotel bed that is."

"Fuck off!" Mermista cuts in, stepping closer to Lonnie. "My man and I don't *do* shitty, alright? You've never *known* luxury like the Pearl Resort."

Lonnie holds up her hands and smirks at the rowdy bride. "Girl, you know I'm just giving Catra a hard time. Figured that's an agenda you could get behind."

Mollified, Merms settles and gulps down half her drink, then burps and says fairly, "That's true."

"You're both assholes." Catra says, turning away to refill her glass.

Internally, she's freaking out a little. *How* had she not considered the fact that she and Adora would have to share a bed? Stupid! She *thought* they could just get a room with two queens, but that would clearly be a huge red flag. The last thing she needs is Lonnie and Mermista roasting her over the fact that her pathetic crush is only coming along as a *platonic* date. And with that thought she fills her glass with a Mermista-esque pour of whiskey and walks away without a word to either of her friends.

As she's looking for someone else to talk to- or a private corner to melt down in- the music cuts out and Perfuma claps her hands to draw everyone's attention. "Alright everyone! If you'd like to join me near the living room, the show is about to begin!"

There's a collective uptick in excitement as the group gathers around the entrance to the makeshift stage. Truthfully, Catra's actually *really* excited for the show- and the distraction. Her eyes have been glued to one particular cute enby who has *no* real interest in her for so long that the prospect of being able to look guilt free is an exciting one. She doesn't need to exert the same self control she has to wield when her gym partner is doing squats, keeping her eyes from wandering places they shouldn't. They're *supposed* to wander tonight.

Even though she was party to the attempted sneak peek with Mermista, she tries to feign disinterest as Perfuma shepherds them into the hallway. Apparently she's overdoing it though, because Mermista, who has officially reached her sloppy stage, is smirking at her pointedly.

"Okay friends." Perfuma clears her throat, stepping very unnecessarily on a chair, waving a paper in the air to grab the party's attention once more. "I know we're all perfect gentlewomen here, but I need to go over the rules for our guest tonight. Absolutely no touching, if you don't want to be touched or focused on, just hold your hand up in a peace sign. Remain seated unless you need to exit, and tips are welcome but unnecessary. If you don't happen to have cash, come see me. Our groom," she pauses to smile at Mermista who hoots and hollers over her man for a moment, "has very graciously provided singles for anyone who isn't prepared. Of course, she has been paid but giving money is part of the fun! Princess will make it obvious if you're welcome to tuck tips, and where."

Catra's poker face breaks into a grin as she sees the whites of Lonnie's eyes grow more and more visible. Lonnie is just as much a bisexual disaster as Mermista, if not more, but found her two gamer boys well before any of that could be explored. Tonight was going to be fucking good, even if a little bit of Catra's interest withered at hearing the stripper's name was *Princess*- not usually a word associated with folks she considers to be her type, too dainty of an

association. At least she can enjoy her friends drooling all over themselves if nothing else.

With everyone nodding and cheering their understanding, Perfuma hops down from the chair and opens the door to the living room. The coffee table is gone, and in its place is a long metal pole from floor to ceiling. Dark filtered lights are strewn all around the ceiling and over the furniture. It definitely looks like a strip club just threw up in the center of her best friend's living room, which in itself was a wild thing to think about. It's really too bad that Scorpia, as the best man, is at the bachelor party tonight with Sea Hawk and the rest of their friends. She would be hilarious to watch, constantly averting her eyes while simultaneously whooping in support. Scorpia is too innocent for this world, her home being the place of this delicious debauchery about to take place is a wonderful sort of irony. Catra wonders passively if she's even aware.

Catra takes a seat on the couch with Spinny and Netossa, and not one of the chairs placed in front of it. Shell enjoy the view good enough from here, content to let the others be in glitter transfer range while she sips on her whiskey. *Beer* is not Catra's style.

With everyone seated, Mermista and Lonnie naturally front row and center, the already dark room goes completely black. A drunk giggle from the bachelorette is cut off by the clear, unmistakable sound of heels against the hardwood floor. Catra follows the sound in the darkness until there's a tang of shoes against metal.

With a power that Catra didnt know Perfuma's speakers were capable of, the music starts. With every pulse of bass the lights slowly came back to life until the ultra violets and reds glow bright enough to reveal a muscular and tall silhouette facing away from them in front of the pole. The tops of her thigh high heels strain against the muscle, and as Catra's eyes roam, she finds herself suddenly very disappointed Adora wasnt here for this. No, she doesnt revel in the idea of seeing them ogle yet *another* woman that isnt her, but this would have absolutely destroyed them, and of

course Catra could tease them about it. Adora's easy fluster is, frankly, a huge facet of their charm.

The ridiculously muscular legs before them are framed by hot pink fringe chaps, to match the hot pink cowboy hat, obviously. Catra can't settle on the hat for long, because her eyes trail down the long blonde hair all the way to the true point of this opening pose. Netossa of all people lets out a wolf whistle as the dancer begins to move. Even more shockingly, her wife drowns her out with an eager cat call. The two of them are couple goals, and the worst parts of Catra hate them a little bit for it.

Catra is instantly mesmerized by the subtle movements. The second best ass she's ever seen and it's covered by a pair of bikini bottoms which are also hot pink, not to mention being adorned with rhinestones which spell out "Princess" topped off with a glittering gold crown.

Princess dips each leg to the beat, making both cheeks, and Catra's head, sway back and forth. The fringe swaying on the edges of the sinfully tight bottoms is why Catra is having such a hard time looking away. Definitely. She didn't realize how far forward she's been leaning in her seat until Princess took a step toward the pole and Catra had to catch herself on the arm of the couch as she tried to follow.

She watches very intently as one leg lifts and presses to the metal, the light not near bright enough for her to fully appreciate the defined muscles flexing as her first dance truly begins. The back row is a blessing and a curse, if she's not going to get to see an ass this enchanting again anytime soon, she figures she should at least try to see all of it. If Lonnie moves at all, Catra is so stealing her spot. She doesn't even give a shit if she catches crap for it later, it'll clearly be worth it.

"Close your mouth dear." Catra swallows a surprised yelp when Spinnerella whispers into her ear. She kind of gay-up forgot anyone was seated next to to her. Catra brings her glass to her lips and

proceeds to try and take down the rest. She doesn't actually like drinking whisky straight, but she wasn't about to show Merms she mixed her drinks now, give that woman any sign of weakness and she'll find a way to pounce on it. Never mind the fact that Mermista herself likes the nastiest, sweetest shit on offer. The sharp taste is working in her favor though. A few gulps is enough to burn her back to reality.

Princess squares up the rest of the way with the pole, her movements are slow and precise. The music crescendos dramatically as the athlete lifts herself slowly, drifting side to side sensually on the pole as she rises, as if it's nothing to levitate with only a calf hook and an easy touch of her hand. That present of a posterior is flexed tight now that she's completely off the ground, and Princess stills at the same time the music stops. She brings her hand up slowly to where the ghost of a t-shirt is tied behind her shoulders.

Oh yes. Catra leans forward, it hasn't even been three minutes yet, and these next forty two are going to be topless? Would this Princess just tease this longer, facing away? Catra's been in a strip club once before, but the memory of it was washed mostly away by shots. There's a reason her and Mermy weren't a good couple, but insanely (and unfortunately) compatible friends. Fake IDs and two eighteen year olds on a mission to sew chaos got them into a lot of places, a strip club happened to be one of them. From what she can recall though, she doesn't remember it being so theatrical.

With a sharp tug the shirt comes untied and drops to the floor, answering that question quickly. Catra doesn't join her friends in their whooping and hollering, instead going back to work on her drink. The music comes back to life, the tempo much faster now, and the lights grow more brilliant and bright too.

She almost doesn't want to look, Catra is still the only single one here and like hell is she about to be desperate all over this woman. Yeah, her friends all think she's seeing someone now, but that's kind of the problem. Adora's pretty fucking hard to hold a candle to, not just physically but also yeah, physically. From the very little she'd

seen of this body however, it looks just as impressive as the one that has made her incredibly thirsty for months on end now. What if this Princess's face is just as gorgeous too?

Catra is going to get so much shit from her friends tonight. Not just for her thirsting, but also for being a greedy bitch. She finally "gets a partner" and she *still* cant hold her shit together in the presence of a gorgeous, talented stripper? Yeah, shell be hearing about this far beyond the newlywed's honeymoon phase. A nudge and laugh at her side make Catra force her eyes open from her extended sipping on her drink.

The horse pasties are confusing;on one hand it makes Catra snort which was painful with the alcohol burning her nose, but on the other hand, boobs!On the other , *other* hand, Catra is left to wonder, sitting there half drunk on her best friend's couch, if crushing on Adora so long has led her to develop a thrice damned horse girl kink. Cause that's not embarrassing at all. Not wanting to be a total perv, she tears her eyes up further, away from the dancing ponies.

Everything burns and Catra almost drops the fucking tumbler on the floor as she tries to stifle the coughing fit as whisky fills her lungs. Spinnerella patts her back in a way that is completely unhelpful as Catra gasps for air. Netossa is snickering even more unhelpfully. Thankfully everyone else' s attention remains on the dancer and not on Catra as she blinks through watering eyes to see if she hallucinated.

Unfortunately, she hadnt. Adora, in more makeup than Catra ever dreamed shed see them in, is smirking in her direction as they slow their spin. Catra wilts into the couch, hoping and praying that Adora didnt actually see her given that one of the larger lights was resting on the end table next to her. There' s still a chance they've mistaken her for some random, hopeless queer completely dazed by their artistry. And thighs. Because, apparently, there are even more of them out there than Catra realized if this little performance is anything to go by.

Catra remains pressed into the back of the couch, struggling for air as *Princess* continues very impressive, very suggestive maneuvers around the pole. As much as she wants to, as much as she knows she probably *should*, Catra can't look away. Her whole face is flush and her own choice of attire feels entirely too warm. She rationalizes that it's not like she can just sprint out of the room without drawing everyone's attention. That is the *last* thing either she or Adora needs right now. However, apparently Netossa could manage it, because Catra didn't even notice her leaving for the water bottle that is now being handed to her.

"Thanks."She croaks out, ignoring the very condescending gaze Netossa is giving her, as if Catra having never seen breasts before is the reason she literally inhaled her drink. Although that would be a pleasant way to leave this mortal coil, choking from tits, the real reason was better left a mystery.

Catra welcomes the cold water, not only to ease the pain but as a way to distract herself, nursing it for as long as possible. The music fades and whistles and clapping take its place. The last thing Catra needs to see is her ex-girlfriend and all of their friends drooling over the only person Catra has truly wanted to see naked for the last eight or so months. Looks like Catra's dream came true, and with the addition of horse head nipple pasties. Good news for her apparent new kink. Or maybe it's just an Adora kink after all- that one she knew about.

As Adora steps out of the makeshift stage, Catra sinks lower into the couch. If it was Scorpia and Catra' s couch from their old place, she'd be able to slip right behind the cushions with little effort. She'd hid there so well to avoid people in the past she'd been sat on once or twice. Who knew she'd miss that piece of junk.

"Well-"Adora says as they return to the center of the room, placing a folding chair down next to them. "I have a few costume changes for you tonight, but this one doesn't stay on for long."Adora brings their hand to their waist and the chaps fall to ground with a thump just seconds later, leaving their thighs, in all their head crushing glory, on

display. Catra is going to die tonight. “So Ithought Iwould of fer up the first lap dance as Cowgirl. The woman of the hour maybe?” Adora takes a few liqid steps over to Mermista, her hand reaching out, cupping her face.

As soon as Mermista’s head starts to tilt toward the back of the room, Catra scowls in her direction. She knows Mermista well enough to have an idea where this is headed. “Definitely later , but from the sounds of it, my friend nearly died there. So maybe she should have the honor.”Adora chuckles and tips their hat at the couch, sqinting against the lights.

“What do you say , Catra?”Mermista calls out in the voice that always holds the implications of a dare. “Ithink you get the hot seat.”

f this couch could just come alive and eat her that would be great. Adora stills, the pop of their hip straightens out and Catra can see the sly smile strain for flash.

“Catra?”Their voice is hoarse but then Adora clears their throat and once again it’s dripping with sex. So, *so* not the context in which Catra hoped to have Adora talk to her like this, or maybe it was, just without an audience. “What do you say?”Adora walks between the chairs, Lonnie’s head on a swivel as they approach her. Adora’s eyes are full of panic as they lean down, and Catra’s doing her damndest to pretend Adora isnt fulfilling a fantasy as they pull on her tie. “W anna ride this cowgirl?”

“Uh, ha, uh.”Thankfully , Catra cant get any redder as the room snickers at her bumbling.

“A w, are you shy?”Adora teases, their grip tightening on the red silk between them. “Ican give it in *priate* if you want?”The way they say private causes even more snickering but yes, private would be ideal so they can talk about whatever the fuck is happening right now.

"Oh no way ."Mermista pipes up. "She' s not shy, just really fucking gay. Get up there, Cat."

They both exchange a panicked look, a look of mutual destruction, but Catra is able to find her legs as Adora pulls her up and leads her by the tie, making it harder to breathe than it already was. Maybe it shouldnt feel as good as it does, the pressure, but that concern is falling rapidly to the bottom of Catra's priority list as Adora leads her to her doom. Maybe doom is too severe- her utter shame then.

"She likes being called kitten, by the way ."Adora' s blush grows beyond that of physical exertion and Catra is contemplating purchasing a one way ticket to another country when they push her down onto the chair. Catra forces her eyes to the ceiling as Adora steps back, but the reprieve is only a couple of seconds long as music returns.

Her vision is obstructed by ice blue eyes staring down at her, and then they get unbelievably close. Adora's breath is hot against her ear as a hand she's only touched while spotting them on bench press or passing a condiment is trailing down her shoulder.

"I had no idea this was the bachelorette party I was booked for ." Catra's breath hitches as Adora climbs over her, their head turning to whisper into her other ear. "W e can talk later, but right now, *Princess* needs to put on a show."

"I didnt think study group was *stripping* Are you even in grad school?"Catra strains out as Adora' s hands run down her arms, capturing her hands in their own.

They growled, "Y es."and "Horses are expensive."almost has Catra laughing. She would be if not for her hands now being placed on Adora's hips, sucking the last of her resolve away. Adora arches backwards, making it impossible to not get an eye full of *everything* Catra is frozen like a caught mouse, powerless as Adora boops the tip of her nose. "Now keep your hands right there, *kitten."*

Hopefully her responding whimper was drowned out by the enthusiastic whistling of her friends. Catra knows her eyes must be wide as dinner plates, because Lonnie makes a comment about the dumbfounded look on her face. Maybe if this weren't Adora, the person she's been hopelessly crushing on, she could actually enjoy this, but no, this is torture instead. Catra just stares at their belly button, nothing sexy there. You know, except the way Adora's abs are flexing around it a mere two inches in front of her face.

Not twenty minutes ago Catra would be secretly over the moon at getting a lap dance tonight, to feel tight muscles flex against her, a pair of perfect breasts in her face, an enchanted apple of an ass over her lap. All that would've been great to take her mind off the person responsible for every wet dream she's had in recent memory. Catra gulps, desperately wishing her hands were at her sides instead so she could have something to dig her nails into as Adora's hips rocked over her.

This was too damn much, there was only so much willpower a girl had. This was her *very* attractive and *very* uninterested friend dancing nearly in the nude above her. However, Adora did literally drag her into this chair. They said they needed to put on a good show, how good of a show would it be if Catra just closed her eyes and pretended nothing was happening? A decent friend enjoys a provocative lap dance from a friend right? Maybe it was better that Princess's first up close and personal of the evening was someone they were comfortable with.

Catra's not sure how much time has passed already, but the way Adora is moving over her, the way their hair drapes over both of them, is lighting every nerve in her body on fire, fueling very hungry thoughts. Their skin looks so soft and biteable over all that compact muscle. Catra could just lean in and…

The buzzed demon on her shoulder begs her to follow her baser impulse;to feel those abs under her tongue. She went to bite her own lip pathetically but the urge to press her lips against something is instead stifled by movement to her right. Adora is giving a come

hither motion to someone out of view before lowering themself down until they are eye to eye once more, this time with a finger resting on Catra's chin. Catra glances away from the bright red painted lips just in time to see the maid of honor dutifully shove a small stack of singles in Catra's gaping mouth. She should just spit them out, but instead she looks at Adora, pleading with her eyes while her teeth hold the bills tight.

The look Adora is giving her is not at all what she was expecting. Adora, or Princess, has a devilish mirth in their eyes. It's a look similar to that time Adora snatched her car keys and placed them well out of reach on top of the lockers at the gym like a fourth grade bully. Their fingers ghost lightly over her skin, around her neck until Catra can feel them tugging at the end of her mullet lightly, prompting her to look upward.

For a second Catra believes that they are about to kiss, right here and now, and it isn't until Adora's teeth are clamped down on the other side that Catra realizes she should probably stop chomping down on the money;this isn't tug o'war . Her ears are ringing from shouting and laughing from the rest of the bridal party, it certainly has nothing to do with how hard her heart is pounding. Adora backs away slowly, their hand trailing down the inside of her thigh, and Catra cant stop staring at those damn pasties.

Everything is hot, her clothes are suffocating and while Catra is aware of what a panic attack is, she didn't know that someone could have a gay one. She's acting like a fucking virgin, shaking as she stands up, very aware of everyone's eyes on her. "Gonna- gonna get some air." Lonnie snorts as Catra stumbles over herself as she heads for the door. Yup, getting some air for the rest of Princess's show.

The part of Adora's brain she allows to be reserved for *Adora* and not Princess'is getting concerned. Catra left several dances ago and there's been no sign of her since. Hell, maybe *concerned* is underselling it- Adora is fucking spinning out. First of all, Princess

has spent the night getting *very* up close and personal with Catra's closest friends-not to mention her ex. Catra's *gorgeous* ex, with a body to kill, heels that rival the height of the one's Adora themself is wearing now, and a face full of flawless makeup. In short, everything Adora *isn't*.

And if that weren't enough to put in glaring perspective just how much Butch Bro Adora isn't her crush's type, the way Catra looked at *Princess* would have been. It's nothing short of painful knowing that all they have to do to capture her attention is slap on some false lashes, torture their feet with a pair of stilettos, and accentuate their tits. And yeah, maybe the whole stripping down to next to nothing and dancing quite literally *on her* had something to do with it, but how much really? Because it isn't like Catra hasn't seen just as much in the gym locker room. And she's been nearly as close to Adora, sweaty and with her muscles on display, while spotting them.

In short, this is a fucking disaster. Plus, while having Catra as a partner dangled in front of her for a long weekend is probably only going to hurt Adora in the long run, they *are* looking forward to it. Four days of affection, in a literal paradise, with the object of many, many fantasies? They should have known it was too good to be true; there's no way Catra will still want to bring them as their date, right? Even if the Princess facade and the blur of booze is enough to hide their identity, things are bound to be...awkward now.

And speaking of awkward, they've been giving the bride a dance on autopilot, and now she's asking something which Adora's only half heard. They lean in close to whisper in her ear, "Sorry, Sugar, couldn't hear you over the music. Say that again for me?"

Too loud for their proximity, even factoring in the music blaring nearby, Mermista repeats, "Come out with us! It's gonna be *so* fun, and I know Catra would just *die*."

And as if her ears were burning, Catra chooses that exact moment to reenter, effectively distracting Adora and leading them to answer, "Yeah, sounds good."

The reality of what they've agreed to registers as the woman beneath her lets out a loud, celebratory, "*Woo-hoo!* Fuck yeah! I knew you'd be game for a good time."

The song comes to a close and Mermista slides a wad of cash into the strap of the barely there bra Adora had put on as part of Princess's sailor costume. They slide off of her and she stands. "Thanks for the dance." Princess says with a wink.

"Oh, my *pleasure*." Mermista purrs and, yeah, they can see what Catra saw in her- compatibility be damned. She may not be Adora's type, but there's no denying the sex appeal she exudes with every bat of her long lashes.

As the bride falls into her seat in the front row, the maid of honor- Perfuma, Adora remembers her introducing herself as- steps forward. Actually, now that they think of it, that should have tipped them off; isn't Perfuma Scorpia's wife's name? It's not exactly a common name. Hindsight, Adora supposes. Maybe if the guy that hired them for this had just given them more than the number to call when they got here anyway. She comes to stand beside Adora and claps her hand, drawing everyone's attention. She seems to be really good at that, and Adora wonders passively if she's a school teacher or something.

"Alright everyone! That is the end of our show tonight. Princess, thank you so much, I know we all had an amazing time. If you need a hand with clean up or loading your car or anything, please let any of us know and we'll be happy to help!"

"Hey!" Mermista shouts over her friend. "This isn't goodbye. Princess here said she'd join the party and come out with us."

"Oh." Perfuma frowns, glancing at Adora. "Well we'd definitely love to have you, but please feel no pressure."

"Perfuma!" Mermista calls out again- a shot glass seems to have magically appeared in her hand and Adora wonders who thought

th was a good idea. "Dont ruin this for Catra by talking her out of it!"

All eyes in the room swivel to Catra who seems to be doing her best to hide in the back of the room. Her panicked eyes fall to Adora and they in turn mouth an *so rry* while the rest of the room is distracted jeering at Catra' s red face. t' s really too bad Princess had to foil Adora's plans to go to the wedding, they seem like a fun bunch- if a bit rowdy.

"Mermista."Perfuma finally tears her eyes away from Catra to scold. "Please remember that Princess is *wor k* and pressuring her to come is unfair."Mermista pouts at this but finally settles. With a satisfied sniff, Perfuma turns to Adora and in a lower voice says, "Like Isaid, you're totally welcome, Ijust know how our *bel e* bride can be when she gets an idea in her head."

"Oh, no, it' s totally fine."Adora assures her , smiling winsomely. As Perfuma reminded everyone- this is still a job, at least until Adora gets dressed.

"Okay , well why dont you get all packed up and you can think about it? ust let us know what you decide and ll see that the decision is respected."

"hat sounds great, thanks."With a wave to the room, Adora slips out and down the hall to the guest room they'd used to change.

"hey open the bag they'd left on the bed and look down at the bro tank and cargo shorts they planned to wear out. Maybe dressing in their usual attire isnt such a good idea? ust in case Catra still wants them to come in a couple weeks. "hey're probably kidding themself, but still dig through for the most modest dress in the bag. Shoes are another issue. "he boots they brought along will look silly with the dress, but if they spend one more minute in heels, Adora is going to lose it.

And thus they emerge a few minutes later in their absurd outfit, only to find that all of their gear has been packed up for them. While they're still looking at it in surprise, Catra sidles up, making them jump when she says, "Hey , uh, *Princess*, need a hand to your car?"

"V ery smooth, Catra!" one of her friends calls, snickering as they pass through to the kitchen. "Just don't do anything that would make Stable dick jealous!"

"Stable dick?" Adora asks, an eyebrow raised.

Catra huffs. "Don't ask. Let' s just...let' s get this shit in your car, alright?"

"Y eah, uh, thanks."

They each grab half the load and Catra leads the way out the door . The walk to the car is uncomfortable and quiet. They get everything loaded up and then just sort of...hover . Catra is the one to finally break the silence with, "So...study group."

Adora sighs, crossing their arms and leaning back against the driver's side door. "Y eah, well. As you pointed out the other day, grad school and horse shit' are expensive." They look down to their boots and kick absently at the ground.

"Hey ." Catra says, a frown in her voice. Adora looks up to see it on her face as well. "Y ou know I'm not, like, judging you, right?"

"Y eah?" They weren't that worried, Catra' s never given the impression of being a swerf or anything, but still.

"Of course not. I'm just...surprised."

"I mean, same." Adora says with a cynical chuckle.

"How , uh, how long have you been doing this?"

They shrug and look back to their boots. "Senior year . A friend helped me get started, she still does the same thing, but she moved away for grad school. S working in Baymore now ."

"Oh."

Adora huffs. "Look, just- Ill get out of your hair and you dont have to worry about uninviting me to the wedding, okay? Id really appreciate if you didnt mention my ...accounting side hustle to anyone though."

"Wait, Adora, what? No, just-Hold on a second."Adora raises their eyebrows and gives her a dubious look, making no move to flee despite a voice in the back of their head telling them that's the exact right thing to do here. "You dont have to leave if you dont want to and"she breaks eye contact, a frown on her face and what may very well be a note of disappointment in her voice. But maybe that's just wishful thinking. "It s okay if you dont wanna come to the wedding anymore, but Im *definitely* not gonna out you, and Iwasnt planning to uninvite you either."

Adora cant help the clear surprise they exude when they ask, "You werent?"

She turns back. "Well . Imean, Ithought...Ithought maybe itd be a bad idea now, but, well, youre not planning on coming dressed like-like *that* are you?"

Adora raises an eyebrow. They have a pretty good idea what she's getting at, but still ask, "Like what exactly?"

Catra groans and runs her hands through her hair, ruffling it adorably. "Like fucking Stripper Barbie threw up all over you. Imean, you were gonna wear a suit to the wedding, right?"

"Yeah"…

"And youve got your face painted within an inch of your life. Were you *planing* to do a full face for my friends?"

Adora cant deny that they search Catra' s face for any sign of disappointment- or any reaction really- when they say, "No, Ionly wear this stuff for work. t' s not exactly...me."

"Okay ," Catra nods, giving away nothing of her feelings on the matter, "so if *Princess* looks basically nothing like you, and everyone but Perfuma is fucking three sheets to the wind, Idont see any reason why you shouldnt come." She pauses then adds, "Unless youre uncomfortable."

"No!" Adora says, just a smidge too quickly . "No, Ithink youre right."

"Great, so...it' s settled then."

"Y eah, Iguess so."

"Um, as far as the rest of the party"…

Adora's heart sinks;they have a feeling they would have had a *really* fun time tonight if not for this unforeseen complication. "T otally, Ican just head out now if you think that' s best."

"I mean, Ithink maybe it would be a good idea to give them a couple weeks between seeing Superman and Clark Kent, let their memories fog a little. f you wanted to come as Princess though...Idont see the harm." She snorts and adds, "Mermista will certainly be thrilled."

Adora takes a moment to think. Obviously they want to go, but it is weird. Plus it's not like they relish the idea of staying in this costume the rest of the night. Then they glance at Catra, and maybe it' s just Adora's imagination running away with them, but they swear she almost looks...hopeful. "Y eah, yeah your friends seem fun. Why not?"

Catra's shoulders relax and she laughs, the sound just *a little* forced. "Y ou just think that cause they give me a harder time than you do."

Adora laughs with her and bumps their shoulder into hers. "Y ou *did* turn pretty red back there. What, never seen a pair of tits before,

Cat?”

She rolls her eyes but Adora doesn't miss the pink in her cheeks. “Not any with fucking *horseparties* on them. Seriously, where did you even find that shit?”

They laugh again, chest loosening, spirit lighter than it's been in an hour. “I have my means. Trade secrets though, sorry.”

Catra shakes her head with a small, fond smile on her face. “Fair enough. You fucking horse...person?”

She makes a little face and Adora has to stifle a giggle at how cute she is. “I'm sorry, are you trying to neutralize horse girl?”

“Well yeah,” she huffs, “but it doesn't really have the same ring to it, huh? Horse nerd maybe?”

Adora rolls their eyes, unable to fight their grin any longer. “Yeah, I'm the nerd here.”

“Shut up, asshole. Let's just get inside before I catch any more crap.”

“Sure, sure.” Catra gives them a dirty look before moving to head inside. Adora stops her with a hand on her arm. “Catra?”

“What's up?”

“Thanks. For being cool about this.”

She just shrugs. “Not like you planned it, and I'm the sad sack who couldn't find a real date.”

Adora deflates at the reminder that Catra's interest in her isn't *real*. And not only that, the charade is very much temporary. They do their best not to let it show though, forcing out a laugh and agreeing, “Right, I suppose this *is* all your fault then.”

Catra just shakes her head, doing a poor job of suppressing a smile, and turns to flounce her way back inside. Adora could say they don't stare at her ass in the tight jeans she's wearing, but that would be a lie and they figure there's already enough of those to keep track of. So they follow that fine ass inside, and resume the role of Princess.

Chapter End Notes

Hi, hello! Lolo here again. Ash (on their way to the barn currently) would like to note that they can attest that horse shit is indeed expensive. Personally I rode a horse once, was much farther from the ground than I was comfortable with, and thus will have to take their word for it.

Anyway, no horses next chapter but we will get to see some drunken pining gays, so that's fun! As always, thanks for reading! And we'll see y'all on the flippity flip. (Which I've been led to believe is how v cool people say "later". so.)

Just Look at Her

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra maybe should have passed on the last round of shots. Hell, Catra probably should have passed on any shots *period*. And she *really* should have skipped her obligatory clubbing cigarette;it only serves to rush the alcohol through her bloodstream faster. A drunk Catra is a loose lipped Catra, and that's dangerous when put in combination with Adora here, with *Princess* here, in a dress that goes beyond bordering on indecent. And they can dance too, which is just unfair quite frankly .

They're standing far too close, leaning against the cold wall of the alley behind the club, painted lips wrapped around one of Spinerella's American Spirits and smirking down at Catra. The boots at least, an amusing contrast to Princess's dress, remind Catra that this is *Adora* . Her friend Adora, who has made it perfectly clear that they have no feelings for or interest in Catra. And that thought is sobering enough to keep her from blurting out something stupid, like how bad she wants to kiss away all the makeup on their face until they look like *themself* again.

"What are you staring at?"

"Pft, *me?* Who, me? Im not-Idont-who's staring? You're staring!"

"Uh huh,"Adora says with a snort, finally relaxed now that they've managed to shake the rest of Catra's friends for this little smoke break, "sure."

"Im not!"

"Hey , Im just agreeing with you."

"S not what your face said."

"Oh really?" They raise a perfectly sculpted brow- Adora has good eyebrows, strong and thick, Catra wonders if they're even made up or if they always look like that. "And what did my face say?"

"That you're an ass."

Adora throws their head back and laughs. When they look back down their eyes crinkle at the corners. Catra wants to kiss the lines one by one, to taste the salt from the sweat that drips down their temples from the heat of the club and exertion of dancing the night away. This is only their second bar for shit' s sake, Catra has a long night of pining ahead of her. She kind of wishes Adora could be here as themself so they had the excuse of putting on a show for her friend to get close on the dance floor. Maybe it's a blessing in disguise, having to keep their distance- she doesnt need to make this situation any more confusing for herself, clearly.

She clears her throat and steps back under the guise of stubbing out her cigarette. "Y ou ready to go back in, dance some more?"

They nod and take a final drag of f their own cigarette before dragging the butt against the wall beside them. "Y eah, Ithink I wanna get another drink first though." They eye Catra with a smirk and add, "Clearly Im falling behind."

"Shut up." Catra says, shoving them and doing more to throw herself off balance than them. "Im sober ."

"Uh huh, go ahead and recite the alphabet backwards for me then."

Catra crosses her arms and rolls her eyes. "Y eah, okay officer. Can you even do that sober?"

"Z, Y , X, W , V, U, T, S-" they begin to recite and Catra huf fs at being bested, walking away to head inside. "A w, Cat!" Adora calls, hurrying to catch up. "Did Iembarrass you showing you up like that?"

“Absolutely not, just proved what a fucking nerd you are.” They reach the door and show their stamps to the bouncer. Then they're quickly enveloped by the volume and humidity of the club.

Adora grabs Catra's hand to lead her to the bar. It's just to ensure they don't lose one another in the crowd, and she *knows* this. Her heart still does a quick somersault. The crowd parts for Adora, or maybe for Princess, but Catra thinks they have a commanding presence no matter their attire. Either way, it allows them to belly up to the bar quickly despite the crowd around it and she hears them order a vodka cran, which she absolutely *will* be giving them shit for later.

Adora turns and over the music Catra hears them shout, “Anything for you?” Catra shakes her head, eyeing the water tap at the end of the bar, and Adora nods before turning back to the bar and sliding over a stack of singles. Catra wonders if they're the same bills Adora pulled from her mouth mere hours ago and a shiver runs up her spine.

Catra manages to shuffle her way to the much needed H_2O dispenser, leaving Adora to wait for their drink. The cool drink is not only a break for her body, but also for her eyes. She saw things tonight in high definition that she's only seen under a veil of dreams. Even though Adora looks odd, dressed like they are, it's hard to tear her eyes away from them. It really is kind of a blessing, given how much more difficult it is to not do something stupid right now, that they have to pretend Adora is someone else. Wouldn't be the greatest for her friends to see her pawing at someone when she's supposed to be in a new relationship with someone else.

They'd hung out a handful of times outside of the gym, but had never gone out like this. Catra just always assumed they would be busy with school, or other horse nerd nonsense. That and stuff like this verged on *actual* date territory. If Adora had come as themselves, it technically would be a date, just a fake one. At least this way Catra

can still enjoy the evening with them without gambling their friendship.

She refills the little plastic cup one more time and turns around. Even through the crowd Catra spots them immediately, lifting their glass in the air in her direction. Catra copies the gesture with a roll of her eyes, grinning like the fool she is. The dimples in their cheeks are as cute as ever as Adora smiles into their glass. Catra is just about to fulfill their half of the cheers when someone knocks into her, spilling (if she's being honest, quite welcome in this hot room) cool water down her chin.

"Pf fft ha, gotcha." Lonnie jeers- Mermista, also laughing, hangs from her shoulder.

"Stars, Catra. We were waving at you but you were being too gay to notice."

Catra collects some of the water with the back of her hand and flicks it at the two with a sneer. "Oh fuck off, this place is full of drunkos. You just blend in."

"Nah, you're too busy getting all cozy with Princess. Mad respect by the way. Don't know why she's spending so much time with you of all people. Did you get her real name yet?" Lonnie leans past her, taking two cups of water for her and Mermista.

"Yeah, does Stable Jock have something to worry about? Cause she seems *super* into you." Mermista reports.

"No, and no. Princess is just, like, cool. We're just having fun."

"Oh yeah?" Mermista challenges, attempting a scrutinizing glare, but instead she just looks like a pufferfish. Catra is half tempted to poke the air out of her cheek. "You've been making heart eyes at her all night. What's up with Sea Anyway? I thought they were supposed to be here?"

"S?" Even though Catra isn't bumbling drunk, she's almost far gone enough to follow the sloshed mental gymnastics Mermista is doing. "Stable." Catra sighs in realization. "Once again, their name's Adora, and uh, they ended up having to work tonight." Catra says with a self satisfied smirk, awfully proud of herself because it's technically true.

"Well, they must be pretty great if you're gonna pass her up, with how close you two have been dancing all night."

Catra looks back over toward Adora, sipping their drink, looking somehow still just as deliciously masculine in their dress. To her it seems obvious this isn't Adora's ideal get up, but they wear it so confidently anyway. Yeah, the goober she's fallen for can really pull off anything they wear.

"Yeah," she belatedly responds to her friend, "yeah they are."

After a bit more dancing at the first club, the party soon moves on to a new location. On the walk over, Mermista sidles up to Adora and wraps her arm around thiers. At the same time, Lonnie whisks Catra away to settle a debate between her and Netossa. Adora doesn't *think* they planned this, but it also seems kind of like they planned this. They don't have too long to think about this however, because pretty quickly Mermista is striking up a conversation. The bride is fun and Adora's happy to chat until they get to the next bar, however when she instantly brings up Catra, they wish she would choose literally any other topic. The last thing they want to do is discuss the gorgeous woman (whose amazing ass is about to send Adora into a trance with its sway as she walks away) with said gorgeous woman's ex of all people.

"So," Mermista begins, finally snapping their attention away from Catra's ass. She leans in heavily against Adora's arm, preventing any further head turning. "Princess. Noticed you've taken a liking to our little kitty cat."

Adora's gut rolls with bitter jealousy, rising up her throat like indigestion. Or maybe that's the shots she took at the last bar. Probably not though. "Oh, uh, yeah. She seems...nice."

Mermista snorts, stumbling over nothing. "I wouldn't go *that* far, but we like keeping her around." Adora hums noncommittally. "She's my ex, you know."

They clear their throat uncomfortably. "She uh, yeah, I think she mentioned that."

She glances at them from the corner of her eye and flips her hair over her shoulder. "Yeah, well, Catra likes to brag."

Adora laughs and it's genuine. They can see what Catra saw in Mermista. They can also see what she meant about them being too similar to have ever worked in the long run. "So, things were just meant to be with your fiance then?" they ask, hoping to steer the conversation in a new direction.

It doesn't work. "Maybe. Seahawks dumb but in a really good way. He's also *very* good at sex." She side eyes them, wetting her lips and with a fiendish show of teeth, smirks again. "Catra was good at sex too though."

Adora's face burns hotly and they wonder if it'll be enough to melt the ground around them so they can fall through. With their luck Mermista would just fall with them though, and then they'd be trapped even longer. "That's...nice." they answer, wincing at the clear discomfort in their voice.

Mermista laughs until she snorts. "Bet you'd like to find out."

They clear their throat again. "Doesn't she have a partner?"

"Doesn't mean you can't have the hots for her too."

"Well sure"...

"She' s into you too."Mermista reports. "Just so you know ."

Adora sighs, because they *do* know, it's pretty fucking obvious in fact;Catra has the hots for *Princess*. Maybe it should make them feel good, the knowledge that in some parallel universe she would go for them, but really it just stings knowing how it would feel to receive that attention from her. "Maybe, but as a rule, Idont pick up women while Im working."

"Shift ended a couple hours ago."Mermista answers, undeterred.

"Is there a reason youre so invested in your ex-girlfriends love life?" Adora finally asks, raising an eyebrow challengingly at her.

She just laughs. "Ooh, did Ihit a nerve? My bad."

"No ."they grumble sourly . "Just a little weird that youre telling me all this when she has a partner."

"Maybe Ijust like stirring up trouble."she teases.

"Hmm, evidently ."Theyre saved from hearing any more as they catch up with the rest of the group where theyre standing in line, waiting to get in the club.

Catra catches Adora's eye and sends them a surreptitious wink that stops their heart. Her attention is quickly grabbed by Perfuma though, as she nudges her toward the bouncer to show her ID. From there, security gets them all in the door pretty quickly . Mermista shouts something about dancing the moment theyre in the door , grabbing the friends closest to her and dragging them toward the dance floor. That ends up leaving behind Catra, Perfuma, and Adora.

Perfuma leans into Adora's space and over the music asks, "Are you having a good time, Princess?"

They ignore the way Catra is watching them closely so that they can answer, nodding and calling back, "Yeah, thanks."

"Can I buy you a drink?" She inclines her head to the bar and, figuring a bit more liquid luck couldn't hurt, Adora nods. She turns to Catra, likely to make the same offer, and once she nods as well Perfuma leads them to the bar.

She orders a round of kamikazes and the trio throws them back quickly. Catra bares her teeth at the sting and sticks her tongue out at Adora when she catches them chuckling at how fucking adorable it is. It doesn't deter them one bit and they stick their own tongue out right back. She throws her head back to laugh and Adora dies a little.

Perfuma's eyes dart between them and she turns to Catra to say, "I was sorry to hear that Adora won't be able to make it tonight." She angles her body away and from Catra's reaction, Adora gathers that there's some unspoken communication underlying the comment.

"Yeah, well." Catra says, huffing irritably and swirling her empty glass in her hand. "You'll meet them soon enough."

Perfuma's posture relaxes so as to not totally box Princess out. "Yes," she comments idly, "I suppose I will." And with that she claps her hands together and invites, "Well! Shall we go join the others?"

She looks to Adora for the answer so they clear their throat and nod. "Sounds great."

"I'm gonna pee." Catra says instead, gesturing her thumb in the opposite direction. Adora tries to catch her eye, but she spins away before they can.

Unbothered, Perfuma beams at Adora. "Guess it's just us two girls then."

"Right." Adora says, another little piece of them dying- just much less pleasantly than when Catra's squeaking laughter was the cause.

“Just us girls.”

Princess allows herself to be dragged to the floor and get lost in the music. Adora however, is elsewhere, mind drifting to a dingy club bathroom and the gorgeous woman inside. They return to their body when a pair of hands comes to rest on their hips and a low voice says in their ear, “Hey Adora.”

They spin around to meet Catra’s eye, smiling at the sight of her. “Hey .”

Catra just winks, her hands moving away so her arms can come to rest around Adora’s neck. She allows them to take the lead, their hands gripping her hips and eyes lost in hers. Adora can feel the beat of the music in the ground below her feet, but her senses are all wrapped up in Catra;her warmth below their hands, the spicy smell of her cologne, a few lyrics falling from her lips as she gets wrapped up in the song, the way she looks careless and free with her eyes falling closed as she trusts Adora to watch her back. They wish they could taste her, the salt on her skin, the bitter lime from their shots lingering on her lips and tongue.

A couple songs pass faster than Adora can track and the group switches partners, Netossa stealing Catra away and Spinerella taking her place. She’s a fun dance partner, busting out swing moves between the usual club fare that Adora can just barely keep up with until they’re nearly falling down laughing. At the end of the song they press a kiss to her cheek and lean in to let her know over the music that they’re stepping away to use the restroom. She nods and lets them go, turning around to steal her wife back.

Adora wanders away, weaving through the dancers and the crowd around the bar until they find the bathroom line. They pull out their phone, scrolling through social media to pass the time. On instagram they find Catra’s posted a photo with the bride, her lips pressed to Mermista’s cheek. The caption is sarcastic and biting and Adora recognizes it as the closest their crush gets to gushing. After that

they lock their phone and tuck it back into their bra- buzz somewhat tamped down.

Once they've peed and washed their hands, they exit only to find Catra leaning against the wall, seemingly waiting for them. "There they are." she calls, a sultry smirk on her lips.

Adora doesn't make the conscious decision to move closer , but suddenly they are indeed *close* . One arm is braced on the wall to the left of Catra's head, the other finding a home on her hip, leaving Adora leaning over her. "You know," they say lowly , voice husky in their own ears, "I think your friends are starting to get the wrong idea about you and *Princess*."

Catra's hands come up, toying with the straps of their dress, eyes locked firmly on theirs. "Let them." she says. "I'm not worried about it, not like we're actually cheating, right?"

Adora swallows thickly, unconsciously moving closer. "No, I suppose not."

"There's a photobooth here." she reports, taking Adora by surprise. They raise their eyebrows, encouraging her to continue. "Behind the bar."

When she doesn't elaborate further Adora asks, "Are you asking me to take pictures with you?"

They don't think they're imagining the pink in her cheeks when she shrugs, winking and answering, "Well, I know you have cash."

Adora laughs and nods, pulling away reluctantly. "Lead the way then."

Catra takes her hand and leads her through the crowd. Their timing is good and another couple is exiting as they wander up, allowing them to slip in without waiting. Catra lets Adora go first and when she slides in after, she ends up more on their lap then she does on

the bench. Their hands go briefly to her waist to steady her and she turns to smile in thanks. They take their hands away quickly, disguising their fluster by reaching into the top of their dress to pull cash from their cleavage.

Catra watches the move with raised brows, dragging their eyes from Adora's neckline slowly and licking her lips. She smirks at them and, amusement clear in her voice, asks, "Really?"

Adora shrugs, trying not to think bitterly about how their usual attire actively hides the cleavage Catra seems so interested in- her eyes flicking back down once or twice seemingly without her permission. "Nature's pocket."

She smiles devilishly and casually comments, "Funny, thought that was the pussy."

"Catra!" Adora says with a scandalized laugh, now trying *really* hard not to think about Catra's-

"What? Am I wrong?"

Adora shakes their head and hands her some bills. "Whatever, just...put the money in, will you?"

Catra stares at the proffered cash for a long minute, an indecipherable look on her face. Finally Adora gestures again for her to take it and she shakes off whatever bug got up her butt. She takes the money, clearing her throat and stuffing the bills in the machine. One it's paid she shuffles around and Adora can't help but groan at the friction.

She turns around, concern clear on her face. "Sorry! Am I hurting you? I can-"

"No!" Adora hurries to assure her, not thinking about what the denial implies until Catra's expression melts, thawed by her burning eyes.

Softly, eyes falling to Catra's parted lips, Adora murmurs, "You're fine there."

"Adora." She leans in, asking *something* with her eyes. Adora's terrified to believe the question is what she thinks it might be, but with the way Catra's eyes keep bouncing between her eyes and lips, what else could it be really?

And then the flash goes off, startling them both and pulling a squeak from Catra. Adora absolutely cackles at the sound of it. "Wha-what was *that*?" They manage to ask. "You sounded like a mouse."

Catra chuckles too and slaps at her shoulder. "Fuck off! Like it didn't surprise you too."

"Well *yeah*, but I didn't squeak!" The second flash goes off as they bicker, but neither acknowledges it.

"Whatever," Catra grumbles playfully, "the next one's coming up, smile pretty, Princess."

Adora's heart sinks at the name but they force a smile and turn to face the lens. Just before the flash pops Catra's lips brush softly against her cheek. They turn to her in surprise and she smiles shyly. "Was that okay?"

"Uh huh. I mean, ye-yeah, that was okay."

Catra smiles more freely and nods. "Good." She reaches out to tuck a bit of hair behind Adora's ear. "Last one."

They both turn and the air is thick between them. Already Adora doesn't want to leave the bubble of privacy they've found in this little booth. At the same time they know it's better if they do so quickly. Better for their aching heart, their racing mind. Desperate to regain

some semblance of normalcy they do the only thing they can think of to break the tension. ust before the flash comes, Adora gooses her .

Catra yelps and giggles and Adora grins at the cute little snorting laughs. t' s gonna be a cute picture, they think. hey hope the machine prints two copies, otherwise they're gonna have to fight Catra for it.

"Ready to climb out?" they ask.

Catra nods, giggles still petering out, and she stumbles a bit as they emerge. Adora rushes to follow and help steady her, shaking their head fondly at this beautiful, unattainable human. hey wait for the pictures to print and Adora lets Catra take them, not ready to look in front of their audience of one. here are two copies though, so at least there's that.

Shaking the photos to dry them off, Catra says passively, "kinda want another drink."

"Y eah," Adora agrees on a heavy exhale, "could use a drink."

Catra looks up at their tone but must decide it's not worth worrying about because she shrugs it off quickly . Her hands are full so Adora chuckles and grabs her tie to lead her to the bar, ensuring they don't get separated. hey order a double for themself, figuring they've still got a little catching up to do with the rest of the party, and a lot they'd like to forget for a while.

his last drink seems to do its job in lessening the reminder that the only reason Catra is looking at them like this is because they're dressed like Barbie Dream Girl. t allows them to forget how the first time they exchanged social media, Adora may have done a little digging. hey didn't do anything horrific akin to liking a photo taken two years ago, but they'd've taken that over the realization that Catra's type was far, far and away from who Adora is. Like, light

years apart. Catra liked spring flowers, and Adora might as well be a cactus. Getting that initially made their heart a little too hopeful. In the end though, the only thing Adora ended up sliding into her dm's were memes.

The liquid courage also does wonders for their nerves of course. Adora feels a little silly being nervous about just how close Catra is dancing next to them, the way she keeps touching their arms, hips pushing into theirs. It's not like they weren't in a much more suggestive, tits out position above her just a few hours ago or anything. Nevermind how used they are to seeing her up close and sweaty after a thorough workout. Then again, that sight has inspired many a late night fantasy, so maybe they shouldn't be surprised after all.

Catra keeps laughing, blushing and being way too fucking cute for Adora to handle. At some point their hands make their way to Catra's waist, and don't move from that spot until the rest of the wedding party rejoins them on the dance floor after going to the bar for another round. They all take turns twirling the bride between them, and Adora swallows unwarranted jealousy as she clings to Catra a touch longer than she did with anyone else.

Drunk and exhausted, they all make their way to a rare open table. Before they make it with the rest of the party however, the tension on the tie Adora is using to lead a wobbling Catra tightens. Adora turns to face her, their heart skipping a little at the bedroom eyes Catra is giving them. They feel a bit like Cinderella. Finally their prince noticed them, if only the glass slipper actually fit. Or rather the stiletto as it were.

"You're looking at me funny again, Cat." They say a bit breathlessly.

"Am I?" Catra humms, stepping closer. "Sorry, I guess uh, it's just still weird seeing you like this." She says as she leans in even further, only a few tormenting inches away. Catra furrows her brows, and from this angle she looks, quite frankly, ridiculous.

"Can Ihelp you?"Adora asks, amused and only a tad flustered.

"Y eah."Catra says softly , her eyes definitely locked on Adora's lips. "I think that shade of red would look good on me."

The moment Catra's hand comes up and brushes Adora's hair behind their ear, time stops. Catra too halts, and Adora can't stop the choked hiccup that falls from their lips as their brain rushes to catch up to their proximity. And then Catra lets out the bubbliest little giggle Adora has maybe ever heard, most especially from Catra.

It' s completely contagious, and soon they're both holding onto each other for support as bodies mesh around them. "Come on."Adora says, still laughing, and they drop her tie to tug a cackling Catra by the arm.

"Where we goin', Primcesss?"Catra asks after Adora fetches their makeup bag from Perfuma's purse.

"W e-"Adora steps forward a few paces ahead, opening the door to the bathroom with a broad sweeping gesture, bowing a little as they do so, "are doin' your makeup. See how that lipstick looks on you."

Catra blinks a few times, mouth closing and opening wordlessly until some club goer jostles her on their way out of the restroom. "Oh- that's not- okay. Sure."Catra sighs and wears a smile that Adora' s not really sure what to make of.

Adora goes in after her, slapping the counter where it looks driest. "Alright, take a seat. Ican give you a lift if you need."Catra makes an indignant noise but hops up dutifully, sticking her tongue out at them. "W ow, you really had to jump to get up there didn't you?"

"I'm not that short, you're just Gigantdork, specially in those boots. Stars, those heels too. Idon't know how you walk in those. Don't you get dizzy? Lack of oxygen that high up in the sky ."Catra is chuckling at her own joke, body swaying with the music bleeding in through the wall.

I'm highly adaptive, now stop wiggling." Adora dumps the contents of her bag on the counter. It isn't much, just a few basics for touch ups in case anything got smeared during costume changes. It seemed smart to bring it with them in case their disguise started to melt away.

They're not going for a full ten minute makeover, the foundation wouldn't match anyway, so Adora grabs the eyeliner and then Catra's face without really thinking it through. Catra goes still, and Adora tries to ignore how hot Catra's cheek gets under their thumb, how soft her skin is. They take their time, trying to get a steady line in spite of how drunk they are, in spite of how beautiful Catra's eyes are. They thought this would be a fun little thing to do together, just some goofy drunken fun, but as Catra stares at them they realize just how dangerous this is to their already weak resolve. It's hard to resist the undertow of her tidepool eye, this close they can see all the different shades of blue and really feel the weight of her gaze. Adora remembers the task at hand and finishes but they have to stop themselves from kissing her cheek as they draw the pencil back. This was definitely not a good idea.

Catra clears her throat when Adora shifts to the other eye, looking up at the ceiling this time, thank the stars. "So um. Uh. Where'd you learn to do makeup stuff?"

"My older sister." They reply quietly, brushing an errant lash from Catra's cheek with their thumb. Adora is more careful with this side, it's always the second one that's hardest. Without tape they don't stand much of a chance making the wing a perfect match, but they want to try anyway. "When I was younger- well you already know. Pretending to be straight, cis, and all that jazz. It's fun to do, even if I don't usually like wearing it. I'll never say no to a little eyeliner when the mood strikes." Catra's nose crinkles up, obviously amused. Does she know how damn adorable she is? "What?" They ask with a laugh instead of grabbing her by both hands and kissing her right then and there.

"All that jazz. You talk like an old hoagie sometimes."

Adora harrumphs, pulling out the mascara threateningly. "You're no better-"

"It's really cute." Catra interrupts. Adora doesn't know what to say to that, the comeback that was on the tip of their tongue dissolves, so instead they just smile and make swift work of her lashes. They only require a light touch, naturally full and gorgeous. Catra's silent when Adora pulls out the lipstick, chewing their own lips nervously.

With a deep breath Adora grabs her chin lightly, using their thumb to keep her lip taught as the red is pulled across. Her lips look so soft, and Adora's never been more jealous of a thing, wanting to be the reason her lips part like that. They try to go fast, but messing up would only require Adora to torture themselves with this temptation all over again. They step back to check their work before starting on the upper lip. The tube is almost to her face when Catra's hand stops them with a light grip on their wrist.

"Adora." The way she says it is almost painful, making Adora's throat tighten. Catra's hand moves from their wrist to Adora's face and they don't resist the guiding pressure coming from those fingertips. They're a fool for doing this, but Catra definitely keeps asking, they are sure of that now, and Adora doesn't have the will power anymore to deny themselves what they so badly want.

Once their lips touch, the lipstick clatters forgotten into the sink, Adora stepping forward as they both collect each other in drunken desperation. Adora was right, her lips are unbelievably soft. They groan as Catra's legs wrap around their waist, her hands digging into their shoulder and the back of their head.

Adora's practically on top of her by the time they stop chasing the pressure. The counter space runs out quickly, and Catra's pushed up against the mirror, but that doesn't stop her from attempting to pull Adora even closer. At the slightest hint of their lips parting, Catra takes the opportunity to dial things up another notch and Adora's moaning loudly. She tastes like whiskey, cola, and a hint of smoke, and it's fucking perfect.

Catra pulls away suddenly, either her departure or the lack of sufficient air leaving Adora dizzy. They're worried for a second that Catra is about to push them away. She should, Adora won't be Princess for much longer- the clock is bound to strike midnight any minute now.

"Fuck, you are so hot."she groans instead and then closes the distance once more. Not to be the only noisy one, Adora grips the top of her thighs, circling their thumbs teasingly and Catra's approval is a throaty, needy, singing one that stokes the heat quickly building toward an inferno in Adora.

This kiss, her touch is so much more intense than Adora ever imagined, and they need to feel more of her. Adora slips their hand down and around and *finally*, squeezes her picture perfect ass. The trumpets and fanfare of Adora making their dream come true takes the form of Catra arching into them with a moan that Adora's going to remember forever.

This never happened in a club bathroom in any of their fantasies, but it's not like what they pictured happening in the locker room at the gym was all that different. Catra guiding them into one of the showers with her, pulling them close, the air around them growing steamy without the aid of hot water. Unlike the showers that provide at least a little privacy however, the door to the restroom swings open without warning. The abrupt increase in the volume of the music seems to plunge them both back into their surroundings.

"No!Mermista, you can't go to jail tonight!Just leave him. Rando ain't worth it."Lonnie barks with a grunt as she pushes a very rabid looking Mermista into the bathroom with her.

Adora jerks back, but Catra' s legs are still wrapped around their waist so she smacks her head against the mirror with a hiss as she's pulled forward suddenly. The noise draws the two intruders' attention of course, and the rage visibly recedes back into whatever horcrux Mermista keeps all that energy in.

Lonnie's realization follows shortly after and Adora steps even further back as their audience's eyes go impossibly wide. Lonnie starts whistling but is cut off by Mermista reversing their roles and shoving her back out the door. "Don't stop on my account. Have fun, or whatever." she calls back, pausing in the doorway to add, "Maybe not the bathroom though, Catra? I thought we both learned that lesson freshman year. Nothing kills the mood faster than a puker."

It feels like midnight has finally struck, and it came in the form of their accidental fairy godmother's future wife. Adora pulls at their dress uncomfortably as Catra rights herself, sliding off the countertop.

"You alright?" they ask, and Catra nods, taking the opportunity to retuck her shirt in.

"So that was-"

"I should probably head out." Adora interrupts, not having the heart to hear the word that's bound to follow.

Catra's head jerks up, looking at them confused and deflated. "Oh, um, you sure? Do you - uh, have a safe way home?"

"Yeah, I'll call a ride. I can come get my truck in the morning. Probably shouldn't drive." Adora reaches out and pats Catra's arm, like an idiot. "Thanks though. I had a good time tonight, with you."

"Yeah? Um, me too, Adora."

Catra waits, staring at the floor as they repack their makeup bag. The mirror reveals the red smear their lipstick had become. Catra's doesn't look much better. It's all coming off as soon as they get home anyway, but someone might want to not look like a hot mess for the rest of the night. They grab a paper towel and run it under water before handing it to Catra. She takes it, giving them a puzzled look.

"You might wanna," Adora taps at their own red stained face for emphasis. "It's kind of all over."

"Right," Catra says, clearing her throat.

"Well, have a good night Catra. See ya at the gym. And don't worry; I don't think Adora's going to be upset about you making out with Princess." Catra laughs at that and some of the awkwardness dies with it. "I mean, I don't blame you, just look at her."

"Yeah," Catra murmurs to herself as the door closes behind Adora. She turns and begins to clean the lipstick from her face with a sigh, staring her own reflection in the eye, "just look at her; a total fucking mess."

Chapter End Notes

Us: Man, group scenes are hard. Do much better with one on ones.

Us five minutes later: And it's a wedding and bachelorette party with all the peeps there…

Anywhooo, thanks for reading and all the kudos and comments, much obliged. (That phrase makes me [o]feel like I'm directly out of an austen novel or some shit lol, but here we are ig, and I stand by it) See y'all next time!

About the...

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra finds the photo strip of her and Adora at the bar the next morning. She doesn't remember giving Adora the second copy, but there's only one in her pocket so she must have at some point. The images haunt her, the memories too. The way Adora had looked at her, like she was worth *eating*, like Adora wanted her... And Catra has the cold hard proof that it wasn't a dream. They made her feel that way when they kissed her too, though she has only her memories to recall that by. She'll never forget though, Catra has never in her life been kissed quite like *that*. She tries to tell herself it was just the booze zipping through each of their bloodstreams, but she knows better; it was all Adora.

Adora who, despite herself, Catra can't stop thinking about. Adora who, despite a short conversation in which they agreed to let the *issue* flow like water under the bridge, can no longer meet Catra's eye for more than a few seconds at a time. Adora who, despite knowing she's only breaking her own fucking heart, Catra can't help falling more in love with each passing day.

Now it's nearly two weeks later, the photos are tucked safely away in her side table drawer, and Catra is standing in her bedroom staring between two sets of swim trunks instead. She should just bring both at this point, but she's already pushing her duffel bag to the limit. Considering Mermista will skin her alive if she wrinkles her suit for the wedding past the point her handy little travel steamer can fix, she's probably gonna have to check a bag at this point. Still, she's stubborn, so she holds up the options to show them off to Scorpia who is sitting on her bed eating hummus and pita chips. Catra had invited her over to body double for her when it became clear she wasn't gonna get this chore done on her own.

"Which trunks?"

Scorpia considers her options with just a little more gravity than is probably necessary. "The burgundy," she finally settles on. "Your top is black, right?"

"I mean, I was just gonna wear one of my sports bras, so yeah."

"You don't have a swim top?" she asks with a frown.

"Well I don't *swim*, so no. I only have these because *you* bought them for me."

"*Oh*. *Right*."

"Stars." Catra mumbles, tossing the burgundy trunks on top of her bag, and spinning around to shove the other pair in the back of her underwear drawer.

"Looks like you're about ready." Scorpia comments idly.

"Getting there. I still can't find my damned dress shoes though." And on that note, she starts digging through her closet. She needs to get rid of some shit; when did she become such a pack rat?

"You excited?"

"For the wedding?" Catra calls over her shoulder.

"Well, yeah. And the trip!"

"I mean, I guess." Catra says passively, putting her hands on her hips and surveying the top shelf.

She's just trying to decide if she can make the jump, or if it's worth admitting defeat and asking for Scorpia's help when her friend says, "Well, you've gotta be excited for a weekend away with Adora *to eat*."

Catra tenses, scenes from the bachelorette party flashing unbidden through her mind. "yeah, Iguess so."

"still cant believe you didnt tell me they asked you out!Ihad to find out from *jde* ."She' s teasing, but there is a note of betrayal in her voice. Catra sighs and turns around.

"Honestly , Ithought it was just a friend thing until the wedding came up."

"thought they asked you out."Scorpia says with a frown. "Y ou said you'd been going out for a couple weeks before the hen party , right?"

Catra sighs and runs a shaky hand through her hair. She's too on edge to uphold this charade right now, but she doesnt have a choice. "W e are-we were. Ijust didnt realize...Idont know . Iguess I did, Ijust didnt want to jnx anything. Make them uncomfortable."

An acidic feeling rises in her throat as she imagines just how uncomfortable Adora clearly is *now*. She's barely seen them the last two weeks!Their avoidance of each other outside the gym seeming to be mutual. And even their workouts have been more sparse than usual. Hell, the other day when they went Adora made up some bullshit excuse about a doctor's appointment they'd supposedly forgotten about, then dipped without so much as taking a shower- let alone making their usual stop at the juice bar . Then of course Starla just *ha* to comment. Catra should have drowned herself in that stupid fucking smoothie and saved herself some misery.

Catra doesnt blame Adora though, she acted like a complete ass at that damn party. When she lost her inhibitions, her common decency seemed to have disappeared too. How many times had Catra tried to kiss them? And still she kept trying? n the moment she honestly thought Adora wanted to, but it wasnt until a few more drinks in that they actually did. Adora was probably just letting her down gently before, and then Catra just had to go and keep trying.

Drunk friends make out sometimes, but she still felt like an ass. No doubt if Adora came out and said no, Catra would have stopped, but she should have just read between the lines anyway. At least Adora isn't too upset with her, since they're still coming to the wedding. It would have been great to actually talk about this though, especially since she can't talk about it with anyone else. Least of all-

"Aw, Wildcat!" Scorpia coos infuriatingly. "Were you nervous?"

"No!" she cries indignantly, spinning around to resume her search- and to hide her red face.

"Hey, no judgement, you've been crushing on them a long time now."

"Yeah," Catra grumbles, "thanks for sharing that with the entire fucking wedding party by the way. I still haven't heard the end of it."

"It's sweet!" her best friend defends. "I haven't seen you like this over a love interest since...you know, I'm not sure I've actually *ever* seen you crush this hard."

Catra groans and her head falls back. "Can you at least, like, *speak* in front of Adora, please?"

Scorpia chortles. "Sure, sure. Not sure I can say the same for Lonnie and Merms though." There's a brief respite to Catra's torture and she manages to jump up and grab a shoebox off the shelf. Of course, she nearly falls and busts her ass when Scorpia continues, "So, I'm guessing you don't want me to mention what happened at the party a couple weeks back either"...

Catra huffs and lifts the lid off her box; a bunch of old greeting cards and ticket stubs and shit- naturally. She's gonna burn them. "I'm sure I have no idea what you're talking about."

"Uh huh, so you *don't* remember making out with *Princess* in the club bathroom after Adora ended up not being able to make it then?"

"Whatever ." she growls, casting the useless box to the side and making a grab for the next one on the shelf. "It's not like it's a big deal."

"So are you gonna tell Adora then?"

"They already know ." Catra says truthfully . "Like I said, we were drunk, it's not a big deal." Bitterly she adds, "It's not like we're gonna start dating or anything."

"Oh." Scorpia says, sounding a little surprised. "And they were cool about it?"

"I mean, yeah." She opens her new box- it's a damned vibe that she forgot she even *owned* . When she gets back she has *got* to do a deep clean. "Didn't Seahawk makeout with one of the groomsmen? *I'm* not the one getting married in a few days."

"That's true, I guess"…

Catra jumps and grabs another box. This time she bumps another one and it falls on her head. Just lovely . "*Fuck* ."

"Catra! Are you okay? Oh my gayness, oh no"…

"I'm *fine* , Scorp." She glances down to see the box that had fallen has burst open and her dress shoes have fallen out. So there's that at least. She decides she doesn't want to know what's in the box she has in her hands and chucks it into the bottom of her closet. "Just, you're gonna be cool, right? Around Adora."

"As a cucumber!" Her tone does not inspire much confidence. Nor does the mention of Catra's least favorite vegetable.

Catra sighs and runs a hand over her face before leaning down to grab the shoes and their now empty box. She walks back to the bed without ever meeting Scorpia's eye and chucks them down by her bag. "What if this is a mistake?"

"What?" Scorpia asks, her troubled expression audible in her voice. "What happened at the club? I thought you said-"

"No, doing this with Adora." She looks up and allows herself to be half vulnerable, just for a minute. "What if it fucks up our friendship?"

"Counterpoint," Scorpia argues encouragingly, "What if, in a year or two, we're packing up for *your* or *Adora's* wedding?"

Catra laughs, the sound more akin to a choke, and she swallows back the threat of tears. "Yeah," she says, "what if?"

"What if you get *murdered*, Adora?" Glimmer screeches into the phone. "You barely know this girl, and now you're gonna go off with her for four days?!"

Adora sighs and falls onto the bench outside their lecture hall. They knew they shouldn't have put off telling their friends they're going out of town till the last second, but they didn't even want to *think* about it, let alone talk. "It's not like we're going alone, Glim. Her friends are gonna be there too."

"Great! Even more people you don't know!"

"I know one of them." they defend, fatigue clear in their voice. They're so *tired*. Between trying to get ahead on school work before this trip, hardly sleeping since the bachelorette party, and working a few *other* parties, Adora is beat.

"Yeah, *fortunately*."

"Look, I get your concern, I do. I trust Catra though, and it's just a long weekend at the beach. I could use the break." they say, as if this is going to be a vacation and not four days of *torture*, sleeping in the same room as the woman who only wants Adora when they're the least authentic version of themself. Or more likely, not sleeping.

"Wait, I'm sorry, did you say *Catra*?"

"Uh, yeah? Who did you think I was talking about?"

"I don't know, some rando or something! Not the girl you've been fucking pining over for months! I figured you would- well one, sound a little more excited- and also, maybe have *mentioned* this when you said you were going out of town 'with someone you met at the gym'."

"I mean, it's just a friend thing. I don't know, I'm excited but"…

"But?"

Adora sighs and runs a hand over her face. "I guess I'm worried it might be awkward."

"Okay"…

She tries to think of a way to explain the situation without getting into it. She *really* doesn't need to hear Glimmer's thoughts on what they and Catra are really up to. "If you know how I told you I went out with that party the other night?"

Glimmer snorts. "You mean the hot bride who convinced Princess to go clubbing? I still can't believe you went along with that."

"Yeah, well." They purse their lips and rip off the bandaid before they can think better of it. "Catra was at the club. She saw me and...and I think she was, like, attracted to me. Or to Princess rather."

"Oh, fuck. Do you think she recognized you?"

"Does it matter? She wouldn't say anything to anyone, I trust her that much at least. Just"… they trail off and groan. "I like her *so much*, Glimmer. And it just sucks knowing that the only thing keeping her from liking me back is how I present myself, you know?"

"Adora, if that's true she's a shallow bitch, you know that, right?"

"That's not fair!" they protest. "It's not like anyone can control who they're attracted to. She likes femmes, and who could blame her? I mean, I met her ex briefly and she's completely gorgeous."

"You're gorgeous too!" Glimmer argues.

"You know what I mean. Sure I have a certain bro-ish charm, but I'm not exactly va-va-voom babely."

Glimmer cackles. "*Even?* What did you just say?"

"Don't make fun of me!" Adora whines, "I need consoling."

"Uh huh, then you should have called Bow."

"Maybe, but he's at work so I have to put up with you."

"Gee, thanks."

"You're the one who suggested I call him!"

"Whatever." Glimmer dismisses, practically flicking away her concern like an errant fly. "Are you sure you even want to go at this point? If all it's gonna do is hurt you"...

"I already said I would." Adora reminds her, biting her lip to keep from explaining why that's so binding; it's one thing to duck out of a casual weekend with friends and an entirely other to leave your friend high and dry when you promised to be her buddy at her ex's wedding. "Plus...I mean, she's my friend. I feel like it would be shitty to not hang out with her just because she doesn't reciprocate my feelings."

"Maybe, but it's also okay to set boundaries to protect your heart, you know?"

"Yeah," Adora agrees, blowing out a puff of air, "I know. If it doesn't go well this weekend, I'll reassess how I'm handling the situation, okay?"

"Okay , I trust you."

"Thanks."Adora says, only half sarcastic.

"I should let you go, but let me know when you get there safe, okay?"

"Sure thing, bye Glim."

"Bye babes, love you."

"Love you too."The call ends with a chime and Adora slips their phone into the inner pocket of their denim jacket. Their fingers brush against the corner of the other item in that pocket; a photostrip they've been carrying around for two weeks as if to torture themself.

They pull it out now and smile longingly down at the pictures of them and Catra. It may hurt to know the heat that's clear in Catra's eyes is only there because of the makeup on Adora's face and the presence of excessive cleavage- not to mention all the fucking alcohol they'd each had- but at the same time, it's nice to know it's real. They didn't imagine it and, in that moment, it wasn't just for show . Catra wasn't looking at Adora like that to sell some story to her friends, Catra was looking at them like that because they *wanted* them.

And then she'd taken what she wanted, maybe an hour later in that dingy club bathroom. It had been the best fucking kiss of Adora's life, and it was barely for them. All that desire directed their way by the person they desire most and...they're just thinking in circles now . They take one last longing look at Catra's laughing face in the frame Adora goosed her in, then they tuck it away once more. A heaving sigh and they push off the bench, off to their last class before the what's sure to be the longest fucking long weekend of their entire life.

The hotel in Sealineas is...bigger than Adora expected it to be. Though they do suppose Catra said *resort*, not to mention that

Mermista's parents are evidently loaded. Either way, the sheer lavishness of the place comes as a surprise and Adora stands in the lobby staring around in awe while Catra gets them checked in. Seahawk is checking in himself and his bride while Mermista lounges on a nearby couch, still drowsy from whatever she'd taken to get through the flight.

Adora was surprised to learn that the rest of the wedding party would be arriving later in the day or early tomorrow. Evidently it was a mix of people buying their tickets late and a few folks being bound an extra day or so by work commitments. Catra had said that Perfuma and Scorpia, plus a groomsman she'd not met and his partner , would be there in time to join them for dinner and everyone else would be there by morning. Not that they're terribly concerned, but buffers will be good. It's almost a shame there's no one sharing their room.

Catra and Seahawk walk back over then, a bellhop in tow pulling a cart with the bride and groom's many bags already loaded. Seahawk looks like it might as well be his wedding day, he's beaming so wide, Catra on the other hand…Catra has an indifferent expression on her lips but her eyes are tight and she certainly doesn't look happy .

"My lovely wife, are you-"

"Not your wife yet."Mermista drawls.

"Well yes,"Seahawk gives, undeterred by the lack of enthusiasm- to be fair given that she's got sunglasses on inside, Adora's surprised to learn she's even still awake, "but in a mere forty eight hours"…

"Uh huh,"she says, standing reluctantly , "gonna need a nap before I can get anywhere close to your level. Is the suite ready?"

"It is indeed!And *this* lovely gentleman is going to show us the way."

"Great."And with that she walks off, apparently assuming the correct direction seeing as Seahawk and the bellhop hurry after her.

"So," Adora begins once they and Catra are left alone, "all checked in?"

"Yeah," Catra grimaces, "about that"…

"Something wrong with the reservation?"

"Not exactly?" Her eyes scan the lobby and she steps closer, close enough for Adora to smell her cologne and see the faint dark circles under her eyes. In a low voice she says, "I swear I *told them* two queens when I updated the reservation, but Seahawk was right there and I couldn't really argue"…

"Oh," Adora's heart trips as they put the pieces together, "so we're... sharing then?"

"I'm *really sorry*, I can sleep on the couch or something. I just-" Her eyes look around them again. "Can we talk about this in the room?"

"Of course, yeah." She nods succinctly and grabs her bag off the ground before Adora can, then leads them toward the elevators.

The ride up is quiet, the silence between them tense and uncomfortable. Catra busies herself with her phone and Adora stares out the glass half of the elevator that looks out over the beach. They feel their stress level rise with the elevator car, up and up and...the bell dings, letting them off on some absurdly high floor. Catra takes them to a door and slides in the key card, letting them into the space.

It's absurdly gorgeous, a small sitting area up front-well, small compared to a living room in one's home, but it's about the size Adora expected the entire room to be. Behind that are a set of curtains that have been pulled back to reveal the bedroom area. Off that are three doors, Adora assumes one is a closet, through the second Adora can see a marble countertop so that must be the bathroom, and then there's a set of french doors. Adora feels drawn to them, walking directly over and pulling them open to reveal a

small balcony overlooking the bluffs and the beach behind the resort. They can see the *ocean* from there.

They turn around, mouth hanging open and eyes wide. Catra laughs, a genuine smile gracing her perfect lips. Perfect lips which Adora got to kiss. The memory sobers them somewhat. Still they manage to clear their throat and say, "This is incredible!"

She smirks and shrugs. "It's alright." And then the expression falls, and with it Adora's heart. "About the bed situation."

"Catra, it's fine, it's not your fault."

"Just, after the other night, I don't want you to think"…

Adora frowns, unsure what she's getting at. "Don't want me to think what? It's just an administrative error, it happens."

"No, yeah, I know."

Adora sighs as it becomes clear they've done nothing to ease her mind. They're gonna have to talk about the other night. The kiss. "Look, that kiss, I know ...I know it didn't mean anything, okay?"

Catra looks startled, blushing, clearly surprised Adora's addressing it. "Right. I'm sorry if I like, took advantage, or-"

"Took advantage? What are you talking about?"

She turns away, fussing with her bags and tucking them by the couch. "I mean, you were drunk and clearly you didn't want-"

Adora laughs. "Is this what she's so worried about? "And I'm the dummy?" Catra turns, jaw on the floor. "We were *both* drunk if you remember correctly. Sometimes drunk friends kiss, but I'm sorry too. I didn't mean to make things so...weird."

"I'm the one who started it."

Adora remembers, very vividly. They've been thinking about that kiss for weeks now. In fact that's why they'd been avoiding Catra at the gym. As terrible as they feel about it, they needed some cool off time from Catra to avoid impure thoughts her grunts and muscle flexion inspired. "Did you? Like I said, we were both drunk."

Catra's shoulders release, face still a little pinched, and she chuckles tightly. "I guess, uh, if nothing else at least we got a little practice in before we have to fool everyone, right?"

Adora forces a laugh as well. "Right, practice."

"So...we're still cool."

"Yeah, we're cool." Adora agrees, breaking her own heart. They'd thought Catra was attracted to Princess, and clearly she was at least a little, but ultimately she never would have made that move if she wasn't trashed. Adora on the other hand, would kiss her again right now if she gave any indication she wanted them half as much as they want her. But it was a drunken mistake, and Adora can be okay with that.

"Cool." she repeats, like she's trying to talk herself into it.

Unable to live with even a moment of silence, Adora continues, "And I'll take the couch, it's no problem."

"What? No, Adora I couldn't ask you-"

"You didn't, I offered. It's *your* friend's wedding, if it makes sense for either of us to get good rest it's you."

She bites her lips and her eyes stray to the bed. "It's a pretty big bed." Adora glances at it as well. She's right but if she's headed where Adora thinks she is- "If you're not uncomfortable after ...you know, we could share? I promise I don't kick or anything."

Adora freezes, they try to swallow a rock that's suddenly lodged in their throat. Their the one who *just* said the kiss was no big deal, so how are they supposed to turn around now and tell their friend that sharing a bed with her sounds like the sweetest form of torture they could ever imagine? There's no way to do that without utterly exposing themself, so they say, "Yeah, okay. We can share."

"Okay." Catra clears her throat and turns to start digging through her bags again. "Uh, good then. Im uh, Iwanna wash the plane smell of f of me before dinner. You mind if Itake the bathroom?"

They shake their head, "Go for it."

"Great, uh, thanks." Once she has what she needs, Adora watches her go into the bathroom and close the door firmly shut behind her.

In order to avoid thinking about how their crush is *completely naked* on the other side of that door, Adora turns around and walks outside. There's a small bistro table on one side of the balcony and a pair of more reclined chairs on the other. Adora goes for the latter and stares out at the ocean for a while, just trying to catch their fucking breath. They'd definitely not counted on sharing a bed with Catra, and if they were worried about surviving the weekend before, well. Now it's sure to end them.

Still, just in case they make it back, they text Glimmer and Bow that they've arrived safely to ensure the former doesnt murder them upon arriving home for making her worry. Once that's taken care of they lie back on the chair and close their eyes. Just for a minute, they just want a quick rest is all.

When Catra wakes them, the sun has dipped significantly lower in the sky. They blink their eyes open and sit up. And then they look at Catra and almost fall over again. Her hair has twice as much volume, the long curls at the back more defined. She's also changed into a fitted pair of black slacks and a silvery button down that she's rolled the sleeves up up to her elbow. She's also left about half the front

buttons undone, exposing a black lacy bra.thing that' s about to make Adora's mouth water.

They snap their mouth shut and meet her eyes. "Hey , hope Ididnt let you sleep too long, you just looked pretty conked out."

They shake their head. "It' s fine. What time is it?"

She looks down at a watch on her wrist with a thick black band. There' s no reason the move should be so hot, and yet. "About a quarter till, that leave you enough time to get ready?"

"Uh huh, Iwas just gonna change, wash my face maybe."

"Cool, Ithink Ill wait out here for you. W anna just grab me when youre ready?"

"Sure thing."So Adora heads inside and switches their shorts and tee shirt out for a pair of nice khakis and a blue button down. At the last second they add a paisley tie theyd thrown in, just to dress it up a little. A quick refresh in the bathroom and they grab Catra so they can head down to dinner.

And then they step off the elevator and Adora sees the absolute last thing in the world she needs right now. Across the lobby, talking to Scorpia and Perfuma, are Bow and Glimmer.

"Oh fuck"…

Catra's eyes cut to Adora sharply at the murmured words. "What' s wrong?"

"Wildcat!" *And* theyve been spotted.

"Adora?"Catra asks, mumbling out of the side of her mouth as they approach the group. "What' s happening?"

"Adora?"Glimmer calls, finally spotting her . So. Now it's officially a clusterfuck.

"You know Adora?" Scorpia asks, guileless eyes wide. "That's so fun!"

"Glimmer . Bow." Adora says, trying desperately to tell them to *be cool* with her eyes. "*What* are you doing here?"

"We're here for a wedding." Bow says, eyes darting between Catra and Adora. "Uh, who's your friend?"

"Aw, you guys haven't met Catra yet?" Scorpia asks, just fully in this conversation apparently. "I guess that makes sense, it's still new, right?"

"Sorry ," Glimmer says, her eyes narrowing as she finds the hand Catra's set on Adora's lower back, "what's still new?"

Scorpia frowns and her eyes dart between Glimmer and Adora. "Well their relationship of course."

"*Relationship?* Oh, *Catra*?" Adora says forcefully . "I told you I was coming out here with Catra this weekend?"

"Right." she says slowly , still darting her eyes between them. "Of course."

Adora clears her throat. "Uh, didn't realize you'd be here as well though, you didn't mention it."

"I definitely told you." Bow says. "Remember , my friend from high school?..."

Adora slaps their hand to their forehead. "I thought that was next month. Sorry Bow."

He laughs it off, though as well as Adora knows him, they can tell he's still trying to fit the pieces together. "No worries! I know you've been busy. With...Catra. And school."

"Oh that's right!" Scorpia says. "Equine studies, right? How's that going?"

Adora clears her throat, horribly uncomfortable with the full group's attention on them. Catra's hand is under their jacket, gripping tightly to their shirt. Clearly she's panicking as well. Yet, she still somehow manages to correct Scorpia, muttering '*horsecourses*' under her breath. "Yeah, good. Uh, you know, grad school so just...busy, busy, busy."

"Well, glad you had time for our Wildcat here at least." Scorpia says with a wink.

"Perfuma," Catra interrupts, addressing the one member of the group who's been silent thus far, just studying the couple without a word, "what time was the reservation for?"

She glances at the clock on the far wall. "About now actually, we should go let them know we've arrived."

"You know what?" Glimmer says, and Adora can tell she's about to speak with her usual level of subtlety-which is to say exactly none at all. "I just realized, I left something in the room. *Adora*, it's been so long since we've gotten to *catch up*, would you mind coming with me to grab it?"

They dart their eyes to Catra and her lips are fixed in a thin line, but she forces a smile. "Uh." Adora turns to their friend. "Yeah, sure thing. Babe, you dont mind?"

"Of course not." Catra says, her voice tight but smile rather convincing.

"Great! Well see you all at the table." And with that Glimmer grabs their arm and pulls them to the elevator. She at least has the decency to wait until they're out of the elevator, away from prying eyes, to start her interrogation. As soon as the door closes to the room however. "Spill. Now."

Adora gives their biggest, most uncomfortable smile, hoping that their dazzling whites might stun her. That or the panic in their eyes will invoke enough pity for Glimmer not to completely ream her. Glimmer opens her mouth with her hands outstretched toward them, as if the words are fighting to come out. Maybe the pity angle is work-

"What the hell Adora?!" Glimmer bursts out when Adora doesn't immediately answer. Next thing they know she's stammering incoherently, just a bunch of wordless, exasperated and *pissed* sounds coming out. After a minute or so of this, she finally manages to get out, "You're dating Catra now? Since when?! Why didn't you just tell me that?"

If they thought that they could possibly have an ounce of chill pretending to be Catra's partner for the weekend, a quick 'yes' and having to deal with lying to Glimmer later would be sufficient. Smart even. However, Glimmer knows them well enough to be able to see the gay panic this weekend is bound to produce. Plus... maybe it would be nice to have a friend to share the agony with. Maybe Glim could hose them down after having to wake up next to her tomorrow? "Um, no. See, the thing is I *am* here as a friend, like I told you, but plus ones are for-"

"Oh my stars." Glimmer says flatly, looking up at them in disbelief. "You useless simp."

Adora sighs, leaning against the wall for a bit of support, ya know, seeing as it doesn't look like they're gonna get any from Glimmer. Just as soon as they've rested their bones a bit, the door to the room opens again. At least the chastising has a time limit. Or so they think.

Bow walks in with a disappointed look on his face. Hands on his hips he looks Adora in the eye and just says, "Explain please."

They groan and move to the bed. If they're getting double teamed, in the least fun way possible, they'd at least like to be sitting for the experience. "I'm here as Catra's date but-"

"*B* -" Glimmer takes over , staring Adora down as she fills in Bow, "They're just friends and Adora' s half in love with her!"

"Adora," Bow says, looking at them beseechingly , "*p*"

"I'm just helping out a friend!" T wo pairs of disbelieving eyes lock onto theirs. "I *am* !She was talking about how she wished she had a date because it's her ex's wedding and the *rest* of the wedding party is coupled off, so I of fered to come. And, you know, since it's partners only"…

"Okay , but if you have feelings for her, don't you think you're setting yourself up for a pretty rough weekend?"

"W ell no shit, Bow!" They say , throwing up their hands. "The of fer just kind of fell out, and once it had there was really no way to back out without disclosing the whole; I think you're the most perfect woman I've ever met and I'd really like to kiss you when we *aren't* completely smashed sometime' thing."

Bow and Glimmer share a glance. Adora's words catch up with them. They fall back onto the bed. "Sorry," Bow says, evidently having been elected to conduct the follow-up, "mind repeating that last bit again?"

Adora sits up. "Y es, yes I would mind."

"Adora!" Glimmer chastises. "When did you *kiss her* ? When were you even.drunk.to- *no!*"

Bow looks between them, Adora looks down. "Now what? W ait, what did I miss?"

"Bow ," Glimmer says, voice tightly controlled, "you didn't happen to give Mermista *Princess's* number did you?"

"What? No, I *oh.* "

"Adora, did you work the bachelorette party?"

They look up, trying for a defiant look. "Maybe." They're not sure it works all that well.

"And you went out with them after ."

"*yl* ."

"And got drunk."

"Barely!"

"And you *kssed* As *Princess!*"

"Just a little!" they cry . Glimmer looks no less exasperated, and Bow seems to be in shock, coming to sit next to Adora on the bed.

"Does she even know it was you?"

"Of course she knows it was me! She knew as soon as she saw me."

"And you two are *stil* doing this whole charade? Don't you think someone's gonna gonna put two and two together?"

"No." they say . Then grumbling more quietly under their breath, "You didn't see how trashed they all were."

"Adora," Bow says, looking a little cowed and taking one of her hands in both of his, "I am *so sorry* , if I'd known Seahawk had any connection to someone you know"…

"It's *fine* , Bow." they assure him. Then looking pointedly at Glimmer they add, "No one's gonna figure it out."

Glimmer scoffs. "Doesn't change the fact that you drunkenly made out with your fake girlfriend who you're in love with."

"I'm not in love with her!"

"Close enough. Come on, are you really telling me you don't see how this is a mistake?"

Adora blows out a breath and runs a hand through their hair. "No, I see what you're saying, I'm just telling you it's too late to change anything. I'll go home and lick my wounds when this is all over, but you pouring salt in them in the meantime *isn't* helping."

"Adora," Glimmer says a little more softly, her brow furrowing, "I'm not trying to- I'm just worried. You're gonna get hurt."

They sniff and look down to their lap to hide the tears gathering. "I already am. She likes- liked *Princess*, and that sucks. I mean, you and Ital ked about this when I told you I was going out of town with her. It sucks, but I'm a big kid and I *can* get through this relatively intact. It would help though," they look up at her beseechingly, "if I knew I had your support instead of you fighting me the whole way."

Bow's hand comes to rub her back soothingly. "*Of course* you have our support, Adora. It's like Glimmer said, we're just worried. We're here for you no matter what though."

She turns to give him a grateful look. "Thanks."

"So," Glimmer says, "you're really doing this."

"I am, yeah."

"Okay then, we should get back before anyone starts getting suspicious." She turns to Bow and gives him a look. "Where do they even think you are?"

He grimaces. "Bathroom emergency?"

Adora snorts and Glimmer wrinkles her nose. "Ew, you can come down in a couple minutes then. Adora?"

They rise and pause when Bow pulls them in for a hug, appreciating the moment of comfort before hopping back into the fray.

By the time Glimmer and Adora had made it to the hotel restaurant, the rest of the group was already seated. Catra had smiled and welcomed her back with a question in her eyes, and Adora had done their best to silently reassure her that all was well. Now dinner has wrapped up and most of the group has dessert and either coffee or port in front of them.

Catra claimed she *didn't* want dessert, just the port, but has had her arm slung over the back of Adora's chair since her third glass of wine and she keeps stealing bites of their tiramisu. The fact that she still has a hand is a testament to how much they like her; the tiramisu is *really* fucking good. Her spoon reaches over once again, eyes still on Mermista who's listing off the treatments she's planning to get at the hotel spa tomorrow, and Adora smacks it with her own.

Catra turns to her with a lazy smirk. "Problem?"

"Yes," they murmur, their irritation only half genuine, "get your own desert."

"*Aww*, babe," she purrs, making Adora's face warm uncomfortably, "haven't you heard that sharing is caring?"

Adora rolls her eyes but their back and forth seems to have earned the attention of the bride. "Are you two being gross again?"

Catra scoffs and Adora's at a loss for how to respond, especially given who's actually *doing* the comment. Luckily Glimmer steps in to save them from responding. "Oh, this is nothing," she says with a laugh. So maybe scratch that *single* part. "Usually New Relationship Adora is ten times worse."

"I am not!" It's not a total lie. Adora would say they're, like, maybe three times worse. *Tops*.

"Oh, come of f it. Ihavent even seen your tongue in Catra' s mouth, and we've been here over an hour ."Glimmer 's innocent smile might be fooling everyone else, but Adora sees the fire and brimstone behind those pearly whites.

Adora's face must be fucking puce by now and Catra shifts uncomfortably, her arm twitching like she's thinking about pulling it back. "Gross, Glimmer , you act like Idont know how to behave in polite society."

"W ell if you do it's news to me."she teases. Adora makes a face that they hope will pass for light hearted while also saying, *Is cool* and also *the is wrong?*

Catra clears her throat and Adora snaps their eyes to her. "W ow, babe, and here Iwas thinking you liked me."

Adora elbows her playfully, heart hammering in their chest, and retorts, "Iat was before you passed up dessert then turned around and ate half of mine."A round of laughter follows the barb and Adora manages to relax minutely.

"Honestly ,"Scorpia pipes up, "Ithink this is maybe the *ost* affectionate Ive seen Catra with someone new ."

"Iat' s true."Mermista says, staring Catra in the eye in a way that makes Adora want to flip the table or something. Just a little bit. "Iey know how to behave!"Pretty sure you never even let me hold your hand in public unless you were three sheets to the wind."

Catra makes a face at her. "Guess Ive just grown since Iwas nineteen."

"Sure you have."

"Ithink it' s sweet!"Scorpia asserts. She turns to her wife and says, "Remember when we were first dating, Honey?"

At this, Catra groans. "I know *I* do. You wanna talk about not knowing how to behave in polite society?"…

"W e may have had our moments," Perfuma says primly , raising an eyebrow that speaks of danger to come, "but so have you."

"And what' s that supposed to mean?"

"Pretty sure she' s talking about the bachelorette party." Mermista heckles, and there goes any relaxation Adora had managed. Catra too tenses beside them.

"Can we not?" Catra says through gritted teeth, sprouting laughter from both Lonnie and Netossa.

"A w, come on! Scorpia said Adora knows all about it. Don't you?" She meets Adora's eye now and though they can feel their face turning even more red, they nod. "See? It' s fine!"

"Merms, seriously ."

She just rolls her eyes at Catra' s curt tone. "Please what? *Don't* mention how you and Princess were-"

"Y eah, that." Catra grunts, her face going a bit pink as well. "Just because Adora and I have talked about it, doesn't mean we need to rehash it with an audience."

"It' s fine, Catra." Adora murmurs.

She turns to them and frowns. Her voice just as low , she asks, "Is it?"

Adora runs their tongue over their teeth. "I think it'll be worse if we fight the current, don't you?"

"I-"

"I think it's really mature of you two. It must have been in the air that night!" Scorpia booms. "Because at the bachelor party-"

"Bow!" Seahawk interrupts, clearly trying to help, making Mermista snicker. "Thank you again for making that introduction. My darling Mermista here said Princess put on *quite* the show."

Adora would very much like to disappear now. So far no one has said anything. Between the makeup, clothes, hair extensions and the undercut now visible, Princess is just similar in appearance, rather than obviously them. That doesn't mean that they're so confident in that fact that a fresh recollection of the night won't get the wedding party to start connecting the dots.

Bow looks at them from the corner of his eye, blushing for some reason and they glare at him because he couldn't be less subtle if he tried right now. "Oh, uh, yeah, no problem, bud."

Mermista cocks a brow and leans forward on her elbows. "How *did* you come across that number anyhow?"

"Oh!" Bow's voice squeaks and if they didn't think it would draw more attention, Adora would just run away to the bathroom at this point. "Uh, Princess and I are uh, well, we went to school together." he says, going with a technical truth.

"*Big*."

Seeming intent on actually helping this time, Glimmer asks, "Didn't you two take a psych class together or something like that?"

"Sociology actually!" Again, technically true, but they'd taken that together intentionally- it wasn't how they met or anything.

"Not anatomy?" Mermista jokes.

"Horse anatomy maybe." Catra mutters low enough for only Adora to hear. They laugh and nudge her. She just smirks at them and

shrugs.

"So, Adora, since Bow and I haven't gotten to meet your new girlfriend yet," Glimmer says, zeroing in on the contact and smiling a little too sweetly at the couple, "did you see that one of the activities the hotel arranges is horseback riding on the beach?"

The way they perk up can't be helped. "No way!"

Adora barely even notices the devilish glint that enters her best friend's eye; they would *really* like to hear more about these horses. "Yep, I thought of you when I saw it and was telling Bow we should go and send you pictures before we ran into you."

"You were?" Bow asks.

"*Yes, Bow, just play along*." She says through clenched teeth, causing a bit of snickering from Perfuma, Mermista, and Catra. Adora's still waiting to hear more about the horses. "*Anyway*, since you're here with us, I was thinking we should turn it into a double date. Give us a chance to get to know Catra a little better. Tomorrow maybe?"

"Oh." Adora side eyes Catra and can't decipher the look on her face. She's not sure what angle Glimmer is working, seeing as she *knows* this isn't real, but she's not especially interested in finding out. "Well, I'm sure Catra has bridal party stuff to do tomorrow, but I'd love to join you if you don't mind a third wheel."

"Catra can do whatever she wants." Mermista says disinterestedly. "I plan to be day drunk at the spa all day tomorrow. The wedding planner is doing all the prep and shit."

Adora turns to Catra, not sure what to say. They know it's probably some sort of trap Glimmer's concocted, but she also knows her audience; Adora *really* wants to go. "I don't go meet these smelly beasts with you, you're never gonna forgive me, huh?" Catra says, clearly teasing.

"Okay ," Adora says, a little of fended on behalf of the horses, even if she is teasing, "first of all I think you mispronounced *jestic* ."

"I'll take that as a yes then."

"Have you seen Adora around horses yet, Catra?" Glimmer asks, all too innocent. "I know you hang out at the gym a lot."

"Uh, no, not yet. Hear about them plenty though." "That' s true. What else are they supposed to talk about while they work out next to their crush? Catra's perfect ass? That seems like asking for trouble.

"W ell you're missing out. They're like an eight year old on a sugar high."

"Okay , I'm not that bad. That would just spook the horses."

"I' s more a vibe." Glimmer accuses casually .

Scorpia chuckles and says, "W ow, now I almost wanna see this. T oo bad Fuma and I already put ourselves down for scuba diving during that slot."

"Ooh, maybe we should do that instead." Catra says, turning to wink at Adora. "Y ou like fish, right? I feel like I remember you saying it' s your favorite animal?"

"Funny ." they say , completely deadpan. Catra just laughs.

"Alright, let' s go meet these horses. B-"

"And ride them."

Catra rolls her eyes but she's smiling. "And ride them. *But if I get trampled* , you have to carry me to the medic."

"I mean, we both know I can bench press your bodyweight," Adora says with a wink of their own, "so that shouldn't be an issue."

"You're insufferable."

"Just wait till you see them with a horse." Glimmer says.

"I think it's cute!" Bow defends, though Adora's not sure how much it helps their case.

"My excitement around horses is perfectly reasonable! You all do realize this is my *career*, right?"

"Area of study." Catra corrects, to which Adora narrows their eyes. Catra just grins and adds, "Horse courses."

"That's not as funny as you think it is."

"You're right, I think it's actually funnier than I ever realized, thank you for pointing it out."

Adora grins and rolls their eyes, but then catches the self satisfied look on Glimmer's face and does their best to stifle the expression. They clear their throat. "So, horseback riding?"

"Yeah, Dor," Catra says, a little gentler, "sounds like a plan."

"Yay!" Glimmer cheers, clapping her hands gleefully. "Just talk to the front desk and they'll get you all signed up and give you the info and stuff."

"Will do." Catra agrees with a nod. "Scorp, Fuma, you two have anything else planned tomorrow?"

"Hmm," Perfuma hums, glancing at Scorpia who just shrugs and smiles at her, "I think we might hit the spa for a treatment or two. I'd also like to spend some time just on the beach while we're here."

"I heard there's a clothing optional beach not too far." Scorpia adds."

"Oh *really*?" Catra looks to Adora and waggles her brows and they curse the way their cheeks heat. "Maybe we should join them."

"Sure, Cat," they say , managing a somewhat even tone, "maybe."

"There' s also supposed to be a really nice hike near there!" Perfuma adds.

Seahawk asks a little more about the hike, mentioning he'd been thinking about going for a run in the morning, which Adora thinks might not be a half bad idea. Perfuma starts talking a little more about and Adora listens passively, thinking it sounds like it'll be easier just to hit the beach or even the hotel gym. They finish their port and glance down at their plate to see there's just one bite left.

They nudge Catra and push the plate a little closer . Quiet enough no one else will be able to hear them, they murmur, "You want the last bite?"

Catra turns slowly, looks down at the plate, then up to Adora with clear surprise. "Thought they didn't share food?"

Adora purses their lips to hide a smile and rolls their eyes. "Fine, I'll finish it my-"

"Not a fucking chance." Catra says, swooping in with her spoon and taking the last bite. She's so fucking cute, and Glimmer *did* just publicly call them out for being too reserved;so Adora follows their impulse and leans in to press a kiss to her cheek.

They can practically feel the warmth of her blush bloom beneath their lips, and it makes them blush as well. When she pulls back and meets their eye, Adora can't quite read the look on Catra' s face. They're pretty sure she' s just trying to disguise surprise at the gesture so as to not arouse suspicion. "Okay?"

"Uh huh." Catra swallows and sets her spoon down carefully , then turns to listen to Perfuma talking about views or bluffs or something. Adora doesn't hear , too distracted by Catra's hands sneaking over to her lap to hold their hand and give it a reassuring squeeze.

And maybe Adora could have enjoyed that, coasting the high of Catra's affection for the rest of the night, but then they catch sight of Glimmer. It's clear from her smirk she's seen everything;Adora giving away the last bite of their desert, the kiss, and the way they swooned after it all. They stick out their tongue and don't need Glimmer to speak aloud to hear what their best friend is communicating;it's a very clear, highly amused, *Oh Adora you're so gay.*

After dinner Catra is drug directly from the restaurant to the front desk, their friends all chuckling at Adora's exuberance. Truthfully Catra is laughing at them as well. They're just so fucking cute, it might actually kill her. Still, she can't resist giving them a hard time, dragging her feet and yawning.

"I'm just *so tired*." she claims with an exaggerated yawn. "Can't we sign up in the morning?"

Finally Adora huffs and stops in the middle of the lobby, dropping her hand (which is so not what she was going for, but whatever, that's fine) and putting their hands on their hips. "It starts at sunrise, Catra!"

And that actually gives her genuine pause. "Wait, it starts when?"

"It's a sunrise ride!Glimmer was *just* talking about it."

"Mermista was talking about wedding shit at the same time!" she defends herself.

And then Adora crosses their arms and pouts, like a stupid, adorable little puppy that no one with a heart could ever say no to. "Well is this gonna be a problem?"

Catra sighs, her shoulders drooping. "That depends on how peppy you expect me to be."

"Not at all peppy!" Adora assures her, suddenly much more animated again. Catra should have had less wine, she feels all gooey now, like she could just melt right into Adora's side. Maybe cover them in kisses, that sounds nice right now. Then Adora snorts and snaps Catra out of those thoughts. "In fact I would literally never associate you with the word 'peppy'."

"Rude."

"Please." Adora scoffs, finally unwinding their arms. "So"…

"So obviously I'm not gonna deny you the opportunity to hang out with your people."

"I mean, we could do breakfast with Glimmer and Bow after they go for the ride." Adora must catch sight of the face Catra is making because they trail off and huff, biting their lower lips to hide a smile. "You're talking about the horses, aren't you?"

"Obviously." Catra scoffs, then walking away to get this nonsense over with.

The person at the desk is more than happy to seal Catra's fate, charging the tickets to their room- which Adora assures Catra they'll pay her back for, as if she's ever let that happen- and filling them in on when and where to meet the other horse nerds. And then they ask, "Are there any other experiences you'd like me to set you up with this evening?"

"Oh, I'm sure we're okay with just that." Adora says shyly, looking to Catra for confirmation.

"I mean, might as well see what they've got, right? We're gonna be done with your horse shit before the day has even truly begun." She can see the concierge trying to conceal their amusement and she smiles conspiratorially at them so they know it's okay to be in on the joke.

"In that case," they say, pulling out a small booklet and sliding it over the counter to them, "these are your options, because we are at peak season, there may be some options that are fully booked, but we do our best to increase the availability of our most popular activities."

"Cool." Catra says, pulling the book between Adora and herself so they can begin to flip through. Most of it looks kind of dorky; boat tours on something called 'ducks' that just look like boats that barely look like they can float, bird watching which might actually sound cool if everyone in the pictures didn't look over a hundred years old, and even a fucking dolphin- Adora gasps and Catra looks over at them. Their eyes are wide and of fucking course they're staring at the page for the dolphin experience. "You're kidding."

They look up, eyes still wide and far too innocent. "What?"

"You want to do *two* horse nerd things on this trip?" The concierge is busying themself now, clearly trying not to laugh. Catra's having a hard time containing her laughter as well to be fair.

Adora's brow furrows and they look back at the book, flipping a couple pages back before coming to the dolphins. They look up at Catra again and say, "I don't get it." Catra looks pointedly back at the book and Adora's confused eyes follow. "The... the dolphin encounter?"

Catra waits for them to look up and as deadpan as she can manage, she just says, "Horses of the sea."

Adora barks out a laugh. "***WHY***"

"Come on," Catra says, finally letting her smirk show, "I thought all horse nerds knew that."

"I have literally never heard that in my life."

"Please," she says with a derisive roll of her eyes, "look me in the eye and tell me that you didn't have the lisa frank horse folder *and* the dolphin notebook." Adora's face turns bright fucking red and Catra points at it like the evidence it is. "I fucking knew it."

"Okay, well first of all it was a horse *book* and the *dolphin* folders."

"Uh huh, and what did your notebooks have on them?"

They purse their lips stubbornly and stare down at the counter top. Catra taps her toes against the marble floor and waits. Eventually Adora mumbles, "Also horses." and when Catra laughs they look up and defend, "But they weren't lisa frank!"

Catra just chortles a little more and turns to the concierge. "Yeah, go ahead and sign us up for the horses of the sea encounter, thanks."

"My pleasure! It looks like there are tickets available for the eleven am slot, does that work for you folks?"

"Sounds great."

"Wait, sorry," Adora gives the concierge an apologetic look and turns to Catra, "Cat, come on, we're already doing my thing in the morning, we should do something you wanna do too."

"Yeah, and I wanna see you geek out over some sea horses."

"Okay, well seahorses are an actual thing and I think we'll probably see some on Sunday, so-"

"You are actually the biggest dork in the world, did you know that?"

"Besides the point, I'm just saying-"

"So you did know?"

"Sure, whatever. Isn't there anything-"

"I just like you to confirm that you're aware you are in fact the biggest fucking dork to ever walk the face of the earth."

"Okay , fine, whatever you say. Are you *sure* there isn't anything you'd rather-"

"*Anything*," Catra moves in close and gives Adora a lascivious up and down, "I say?"

They turn beet fucking red again and Catra barely manages to withhold her cackling. "Catra!"

"Yes, dear?" They sigh and run a shaky hand through their hair. "It's adorable and Catra finds herself wishing they could use their shared king size bed for activities far more interesting than *sleep*. Though now she thinks about it, if she has to get up at sunrise they really *should* wrap this up and get to bed. A little softer she says, "Adora, I'm sure."

"O-okay , yeah."

Catra gives her a long look, waiting to make sure she's not gonna be any more of a pain in the ass about this, then she turns back to the waiting concierge. "Thanks for waiting. We'll take the eleven o'clock tickets."

They nod. "You are all set."

"Appreciate you."

"Have a lovely night."

Both she and Adora nod in thanks and she uses a hand on Adora's lower back to guide them to the elevator and back to their room. Once there Adora changes in the bathroom and Catra takes the sitting area, then she joins them in the bathroom to brush teeth. The air between them is slowly growing tense as bedtime draws near, and Adora breaks that tension as only they could.

“Are you *sure* you don't mind doing the horses and the dolphins? Cause I'm sure-”

Catra spits and gives them a look in the mirror. “Adora?”

“Yes?”

“Fuck off.”

They laugh abruptly, giving her a look of surprise as she goes back to brushing her teeth. Softly, eyes still on her in the mirror, they say, “just- it's your vacation too, Cat.”

She sighs and spits again, meeting their eye in the mirror. “I know it is, Adora, and if I really didn't want to go, I would say. You're also doing me this favor, and going to a relative stranger's wedding- which, by the way, is going to be an all day fucking circus on Sunday. The least I can do is go with you to meet a fucking horse of the sea.”

They laugh and smile like they're reassured, but Catra can't help but notice that it doesn't reach their eyes. “Okay, if you're sure. Thank you.”

“You bet, dummy.”

They chuckle a little under their breath before tapping the toothbrush against the sink, obviously trying to figure out how to say something. “So,” Adora says with a heavy breath. “Glimmer and Bow. I didn't know they were going to be here. I kind of had to tell them about our arrangement.”

Catra pauses, toothbrush dangling out of her mouth. “Are they gonna rat us out?” It would be just her luck that in this once in a lifetime chance to pretend even a little that Adora was hers, that it would be foiled by even more unlikely circumstances. The fact that Adora's friends were at this wedding too floored her, but at least now Adora would have other people to hang out with if Catra ends up passing away from the next peck Adora gives her.

"No, neither of them would do that." They said confidently, then grimaced. "But I think Glimmer is gonna be giving us a hard time."

Honestly, she can respect that. Catra would probably do the same if the roles were reversed.

"Well, you were quite the actor at dinner. Didn't think you'd be able to keep up with me, nice to know I won't be carrying us all weekend." That cheek kiss caught her so off guard, and even if it was for show, Catra will take all she can get before she has to go back into real life where Adora would much rather be doing that with juice queen Starla.

Adora clears their throat as they rinse out their toothbrush. "Right, uh, thanks. I'll do my best. Stuff like that is still okay yeah? Like we talked about. Cheek kisses, little affections, for show?"

Catra eyes them, and finds that Adora looks as nervous as she had been when the plane was taking off this morning. "Yeah, Dor. Don't worry, I'm not gonna shove my tongue down your throat again. Unless." Catra pauses, grinning wildly at the stunned look Adora is giving her.

"Unless?" Adora strains out, looking at her with wide eyes. No, Catra isn't going to put them through that again, even if they are both drunk. She'll take all this agreed upon affection, but she's not so low as to take advantage of them, of this situation. Now if Adora *wanted* to, without Catra prompting it, then sure, but that's never going to happen. Catra got her reality smashing lip crashing with Adora once, can't really expect to get that lucky twice.

"Unless." Catra swallows the words she wants to say, the words that want to come out instead of this jab. "one of the horses knocks you out of course, and I have to give you cpr." Adora scoffs and Catra is chuckling.

"That's not how you give cpr. Remind me to make sure there's a lifeguard around if we go swimming."

"Of course that' s how you give cpr, my instructor was very thorough."

"Mmhmm. Im sure whatever pretty girl told you that had ulterior motives."

Catra laughs and then before knows it, theyre climbing under the covers, each staying as far to their own side of the bed as they can manage. Catra bets Adora is a good cuddler. Historically she hasnt even been much of a cuddler herself, but she would *be* to make an exception in this case. f only Adora wanted her to.

Instead they murmur a quiet, "Ghight Catra."and roll away , facing the closed curtains.

"Good night, Adora."she whispers back, hoping Adora doesnt hear how dejected she feels in her voice. Or if they do, they mistake it for her being tired, which she is of course. t still takes her nearly an hour of listening to feather light snores and her own pounding heart to finally fall asleep.

Chapter End Notes

Hii!As always, thanks for reading!No notes from either raptor or myself this time. So Iguess... go forth, and be gay!

End Notes

Hi!Lolo here posting chapter 1!So excited to get this bad boi up!This is my first collab and it's been so, so fun working with Raptor. Things in this world are about to get...real messy . And fun!For us. And you, the readers. Our main characters have some pining to do first, but they'll get there and have some fun along the way too!Okay , I think that's all I have for now!The following note was brought to you by my illustrious co-author... RaptorRed : I'm so happy to finally use "Stars!" As an expletive

As always, thanks for reading, and I'll see ya soon!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!